



Security Council

Seventy-eighth year

Provisional

9327th meeting

Tuesday, 23 May 2023, 3 p.m.

New York

<i>President:</i>	Mr. Hauri/Mrs. Chanda	(Switzerland)
<i>Members:</i>	Albania	Ms. Prizreni
	Brazil	Mr. Silveira Braoios
	China	Mr. He Zhiqiang
	Ecuador	Mr. Montalvo Sosa
	France	Ms. Lebatteux
	Gabon	Mr. Nanga
	Ghana	Mrs. Corquaye
	Japan	Mr. Magosaki
	Malta	Mr. De Bono Sant Cassia
	Mozambique	Mr. Bambissa
	Russian Federation	Mr. Vorobiev
	United Arab Emirates	Mr. Alolama
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland . .	Ms. Alldridge
	United States of America	Ms. Hoey

Agenda

Protection of civilians in armed conflict

Ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in conflict: addressing food insecurity and protecting essential services

Letter dated 1 May 2023 from the Permanent Representative of Switzerland to the United Nations addressed to the Secretary-General (S/2023/307)

Report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians in armed conflict (S/2023/345)

This record contains the text of speeches delivered in English and of the translation of speeches delivered in other languages. The final text will be printed in the *Official Records of the Security Council*. Corrections should be submitted to the original languages only. They should be incorporated in a copy of the record and sent under the signature of a member of the delegation concerned to the Chief of the Verbatim Reporting Service, room AB-0601 (verbatimrecords@un.org). Corrected records will be reissued electronically on the Official Document System of the United Nations (<http://documents.un.org>).



The meeting resumed at 3.05 p.m.

The President (*spoke in French*): I would like to remind all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes in order to enable the Council to carry out its work expeditiously. Flashing lights on the collar of the microphone will prompt speakers to bring their remarks to a close after three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Ukraine.

Mr. Kyslytsya (Ukraine): Ukraine highly appreciates the initiative of the Swiss presidency to hold this important debate and would like to thank the briefers for their statements.

As the Secretary-General said today, war means hunger. It is indeed an outrage that more than 117 million people faced acute hunger because of war and insecurity. Hundreds of civilians were killed recently in the Sudan, and 43,000 people, half of them children, died in Somalia last year as a result of drought. That is horrendous.

Five years since resolution 2417 (2018) was adopted, the task of breaking the vicious cycle of armed conflict and food insecurity remains a goal rather than a reality.

The Russian war against Ukraine is one of the most powerful examples. It is not the first time that Ukraine has withstood Moscow's inhumane practice of the weaponization of food. This year, my country is commemorating the ninetieth anniversary of the Great Famine caused by Stalin's regime, which took the lives of millions in Ukraine. Those painful memories are now among the main sources of Ukrainian resistance to the modern-day invaders.

There are several lessons from the Russian war that would be useful for further deliberation on the nexus between conflict and food insecurity.

First, starvation remains an essential element in the aggressive toolbox to undermine the defensive capacities of the attacked State and to suppress the civilian population in occupied areas. Since the beginning of the invasion, Moscow has resorted to blocking humanitarian corridors and humanitarian access to besieged and occupied areas. Severe restrictions on movement imposed by the Russian troops on the local residents in the occupied territories have deprived the civilians of adequate access to food and water. Starvation has also been used as torture against detainees in the occupied territories and Ukrainian prisoners of war.

Secondly, the aggressor tries to convert global food-related concerns into resentment against the victim of aggression and to discredit his legitimate self-defence by referring to the needs of affected countries and regions. It is an element of the aggressor's efforts to persuade the world to accept its vision of a resolution that is an invitation for the attacked State to surrender. To that end, the aggressor tries to undermine multilateral initiatives to respond to crises, such as the Black Sea Grain Initiative in the case of the Russian war. In the framework of that initiative, Moscow is trying to blackmail, impede and diminish the contribution of Ukraine to global food security.

Thirdly, we must address the long-lasting impact of armed conflict on food security, which includes mine contamination of agricultural lands, as well as the destruction of critical infrastructure, undermining food production, distribution and access to food and water.

Fourthly, the United Nations should be an indispensable part of the global efforts to address the grave consequences of war for civilian populations. In our case, that includes brokering by the United Nations, along with Türkiye, the Black Sea Grain Initiative, as well as its humanitarian response, to provide life-saving support to Ukrainian civilians on the ground in extremely dangerous conditions.

My fifth point is that a comprehensive solution can only be ensured when respect for the United Nations Charter is restored. We urge the States Members of the United Nations to contribute to the implementation of the General Assembly resolution on a comprehensive, just and lasting peace in Ukraine consistent with the principles set forth in the United Nations Charter (General Assembly resolution ES-11/6). We also believe that only by holding the perpetrators of the crime of aggression accountable will we be able to prevent armed conflicts in future and, as a result, prevent civilians from further suffering.

(spoke in French)

I would like to conclude my statement by thanking the Swiss presidency for its exceptional leadership in the work of the Council, which has allowed us to tackle the topics that require our urgent and common action. I am convinced that the citizens of the Swiss Confederation should be proud of the way their leaders and diplomats represent their country on the international stage in terms of promoting the purposes and principles of the United Nations Charter.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Republic of Korea.

Mr. Hwang (Republic of Korea): I would like to thank the Secretary-General and the other briefers for their informative remarks.

The Security Council has, under its agenda, addressed the protection of civilians in armed conflict for more than 20 years. In particular, in its resolution 2417 (2018), the Council emphasized the causal link between armed conflict and food insecurity and the threat of famine. However, five years after the adoption of this resolution, the recent report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) paints a much grimmer picture.

Conflict remains the primary driver of hunger. More than 100 million people are experiencing high levels of acute food insecurity in 19 countries and territories. Essential services can be destroyed or rendered useless by armed conflicts. Hostilities have driven farmers out and destroyed farmland and food-related infrastructure in Mali and Somalia. Conflicts have aggravated water scarcity by damaging water resources in the Horn of Africa. Electricity and health systems are no exception.

Keeping these bleak pictures in mind, my delegation would like to make a few points. First and foremost, ensuring safe, unimpeded and unconditional humanitarian access is crucial to addressing the imperative needs caused by food shortages in conflict-affected regions. In this vein, United Nations peacekeeping missions, with their protection mandates, need to be more proactive in safeguarding humanitarian space and strengthening coordination with humanitarian actors on the ground through the timely sharing of information.

Secondly, the Security Council should consider introducing a monitoring-and-reporting mechanism that already exists in the context of children and armed conflict. Such a mechanism could provide us with a clearer picture of any violations related to conflict-induced food insecurity and damage to essential services. This will contribute to pursuing accountability and ensuring compliance with relevant international humanitarian law.

Thirdly, parties to armed conflict should act in a manner that avoids or at least minimizes the impact of their operations on essential services. As the disruption of essential services is not beneficial even to warring parties, they need to consider cooperating with each

other to protect them. The actual impact of hostilities on such systems could be analysed and included in reports of the Secretary-General.

It is time to translate all the commitments for the protection of civilians into meaningful action. The President of the Republic of Korea has a firm belief that we can overcome various global crises with the spirit of cooperation and solidarity in the international community. On the occasion of the Group of Seven summit in Hiroshima last weekend, President Yoon pledged that my Government will double the amount of rice aid from the current 50,000 tons to 100,000 tons annually to six food-crisis-ridden countries. In addition, he announced the new K-Rice Belt project, which will contribute to increasing the long-term rice-producing capacity of seven African countries with a view to providing rice to 30 million people in five years in a stable manner.

The Republic of Korea stands ready to engage further with the international community to enhance the protection of civilians in armed conflict, especially those confronting food insecurity.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mrs. Kamboj (India): I take this opportunity to convey best wishes from my Prime Minister to the President of the Swiss Confederation.

The level of food insecurity in the world has indeed reached alarming proportions. It is projected that the number of people who will be food-insecure this year will be double the number it was in 2020. The ongoing conflicts in many parts of the world, including in Ukraine and Afghanistan — in our neighbourhood — have only exacerbated the crisis.

The steps we need to take are therefore clear. Allow me to make four quick points. First, collective and common solutions through dialogue and diplomacy are the need of the hour. We support the efforts of the Secretary-General to find ways to address the challenge of global food insecurity. In this way, we welcome the extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative. As the Chair of the Group of 20 this year, India is making efforts to address the current challenges to food and energy security and ensure that humanitarian needs of vulnerable communities are met without delay.

Secondly, rapid humanitarian access to people in need in all areas affected by conflict and violence is critical. We also need to avoid linking humanitarian

assistance with political issues. I will say in this regard that India has provided critical humanitarian assistance, in particular by supplying food grains to countries facing conflicts, including Ukraine, Afghanistan, Yemen and Myanmar.

Thirdly, armed conflict and terrorism, combined with extreme weather, crop pests, food-price volatility, exclusion and economic shocks can devastate any fragile economy, leading to food insecurity and an increased threat of famine. Capacity-building support to countries facing such threats in designing, implementing and monitoring policies and programmes related to food security is therefore extremely critical.

Fourthly, it is imperative for all of us to adequately appreciate the importance of equity, affordability and accessibility when it comes to food grains. Open markets should not become an argument to perpetuate inequity, which would only discriminate against the global South.

Finally, confronted with growing challenges throughout the world, India will never be found wanting in extending a helping hand to those who may be in distress. We will continue to walk the talk when it comes to assisting our partners in need.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Kuwait.

Mr. Albanai (Kuwait): I am honoured to take the floor on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict, a cross-regional network of 27 States Members of the United Nations.

At the outset, and on behalf of the Group of Friends, I would like to extend warm congratulations to Switzerland on its historic and first-ever presidency of the Security Council. The Group of Friends is most pleased to see one of its own presiding over the Council this month. Switzerland has steered the work of the Council in the most efficient manner, and we wish it the best of luck for the remaining days of its presidency.

The Security Council must redouble its efforts aimed at breaking the cycle of armed conflict, which drives and sustains many humanitarian crises around the world. Together, as the United Nations, we must do all we can to use the full range of tools at our disposal to prevent and end conflicts.

Civilians are consistently shouldering the burden of conflicts around the world. Today 2 billion people — a quarter of humankind — live in places

affected by armed conflict. Record numbers of civilians are facing the humanitarian consequences of conflict, including displacement and food and nutrition insecurity. Among all civilians affected by armed conflict, those in vulnerable situations who are disproportionately prone to suffering, especially children, require our particular attention.

This year's report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345) focuses sharply on conflict and hunger. The report identifies a continuously high number of persons facing crisis levels of acute food and nutrition insecurity, primarily caused by the consequences of armed conflicts. It notes that, in 2022, more than a quarter of a billion people faced acute hunger in 58 countries and territories, many of which were in situations of armed conflict. Furthermore, conflict and insecurity were the most significant drivers of high levels of acute food insecurity for around 117 million people in 19 countries and territories.

Stronger efforts are required to prevent and alleviate hunger in armed conflicts, including by protecting food sources and respecting and protecting humanitarian relief objects and personnel, in line with obligations under international humanitarian law. As enshrined in international humanitarian law and reaffirmed by the relevant Council resolutions, such as resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), the use of starvation of civilians, including children, as a method of warfare is prohibited.

The Group of Friends calls on all parties to armed conflict to comply with their obligations under international humanitarian law with regard to respecting and protecting civilians and taking constant care to spare civilian objects, including those necessary for food production and distribution such as farms, markets, water systems, mills, food processing and storage sites and hubs and means for food transportation, as well as refraining from attacking, destroying, removing or rendering useless objects that are indispensable to the survival of the civilian population.

Furthermore, reporting and evidence of food and nutrition insecurity and famine risk must be swift and timely, and the Council must respond with rapid and decisive action. Too often our response is too little and too late. It is timely to recall that tomorrow, 24 May, marks the fifth anniversary of the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018). Yet much more needs to be done to ensure respect for international humanitarian law and the full implementation of that resolution.

Armed conflicts also inevitably contribute to the degradation of the environment, which in turn affects essential services such as those related to the delivery of food and water. The consequences for civilians are compounded by the effects of climate change, as well as the collapse of food systems and supply chains.

Armed conflicts are increasingly being fought in urban areas, where countless civilians are killed and injured. The Group of Friends echoes the Secretary-General's concern, as described in his report, about the humanitarian consequences resulting from armed conflicts involving the use of explosive weapons in populated areas. The Group repeats its urgent call to all parties to conflict to respect international humanitarian law and international human rights law, and to those with influence over them to ensure such respect. The Group of Friends notes the recent adoption, in Dublin on 18 November 2022, of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas.

Furthermore, forced displacement exacerbates food and nutrition insecurity. As people flee the fighting, they also abandon their crops, and often their livestock, undermining the food supply for entire regions. When they return, it is often no longer possible to cultivate the fields, as they can be riddled with mines or other explosive remnants.

The protection of civilians must also be strengthened through the protection of objects indispensable for the survival of the population, including civilian infrastructure critical for the delivery of interconnected and essential basic services. Too often, a lack of electricity, water and other basic commodities hampers the delivery of the most essential services, such as education and medical care, placing the health and welfare of civilians at risk.

It is important to recall that the Council has adopted resolution 2286 (2016), which strongly condemns attacks against medical facilities and personnel in conflict situations; resolution 2573 (2022), on the protection of civilian infrastructure; and resolution 2601 (2021), on the protection of schools, educational facilities and civilians connected with schools, including children and teachers. The Group of Friends calls on Member States and other relevant actors to advance the implementation of those important Council resolutions and the international humanitarian law obligations that underpin them.

Humanitarian organizations work tirelessly to preserve and re-establish access to essential services for the affected civilian population. There is an urgent need to redouble efforts, including in the Council, to allow and facilitate full, safe, timely and unhindered humanitarian access, as well as the safety and security of all humanitarian personnel, in accordance with international humanitarian law.

The Group of Friends commends the Security Council on the adoption of resolution 2664 (2022), regarding humanitarian exemptions to assets freezes under United Nations sanctions regimes. That is a pivotal step for the facilitation of humanitarian assistance in some of the most complex circumstances.

We are deeply concerned about the growing number of missing persons as a result of armed conflict. Efforts to prevent family separation and disappearances, to search for and identify missing and deceased persons and to address the needs of affected families should be an integral part of our response. Taking early action at the onset of an armed conflict is crucial. The regional and national implementation of the relevant obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law, as well as of resolution 2474 (2019), on missing persons, is key.

Lastly, the use of new technologies is becoming increasingly important for efficient and effective humanitarian operations and the protection of civilians. However, modern technologies, including social media, are all too often misused for false narratives about humanitarian organizations and their work, as well as the work of United Nations missions. Misinformation and disinformation endanger the security of humanitarian and United Nations mission staff, as well as that of the people they are supposed to serve. That must be vigorously combatted, including by advocating for international humanitarian law and humanitarian principles.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Philippines.

Mr. Lagdameo (Philippines): We congratulate Switzerland for holding this annual open debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict as one of the signature events of its Security Council presidency. We also thank the Secretary-General, the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross and the other briefers for their briefings and insightful views.

In today's Security Council open debate, which coincides with the sixth edition of Protection of Civilians week, we have been invited to share our views on both challenges and good practices, including preventive and preparedness measures on how to better ensure the survival, security and dignity of the civilian population in times of conflict. Indeed, civilians continue to bear the brunt of armed conflicts. We note the assessment of the World Food Programme and the Food and Agriculture Organization that 70 per cent of the world's population experiencing acute hunger are in conflict-affected areas.

The Philippines supports all efforts, including those led by the United Nations, to protect civilians affected by armed conflict. Our commitment is anchored in our devotion to international humanitarian law and our firm belief that international human rights law also applies in situations of armed conflict. We therefore support the view that respect for international humanitarian law and international human rights law is crucial to prevent hunger and further suffering in conflict situations and protect the civilian population and civilian objects in general. We also agree that international humanitarian law provides the legal framework to strategically mitigate the impacts of armed conflict and is applicable to the use of explosive weapons in populated areas. While international humanitarian law applies to both States and armed non-State actors in times of armed conflict, our national experience demonstrates that armed non-State actors have a greater propensity to violate international humanitarian law, owing to either a demonstrable lack of understanding or incentives to comply. Accountability mechanisms that exist in States are also often absent among non-State actors. We welcome the condemnation by both States and armed non-State actors of tactics that exploit the proximity of civilians and civilian objects to military objectives in populated areas. We reaffirm our common commitment to end impunity and welcome the affirmation of obligations to hold accountable those responsible for violations of international humanitarian law.

The protection of civilians is front and centre of peacekeeping operations. The Philippines believes that success in peacekeeping operations must be measured by how well we protect civilians and how effectively we ensure the sustainment of the environments for peace to flourish. Throughout the years, whether at a substantive session of the Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations or a Security Council open debate, we have

been consistent in our position on the protection of civilians. Expectations regarding protection tasks must be succinct and clear, connected to political strategies in the field and focused on prevention. A people-centred New Agenda for Peace should promote and enhance the protection of civilians in armed conflicts, supported by strong adherence to international humanitarian law and the Charter of the United Nations.

The protection of civilians in situations of armed conflict is a priority for the Philippines, in line with laws like the Philippine Act on Crimes Against International Humanitarian Law, Genocide and Other Crimes Against Humanity and the Special Protection of Children in Situations of Armed Conflict Law. Next year, we hope to further enhance our active participation in the protection of civilians affected by armed conflicts, with the projected increase of Filipino peacekeepers on the ground. We also reiterate our support for the Convention on Cluster Munitions, as their prohibition protects civilians and civilian infrastructure, especially in urban conflict areas.

Lastly, today's open debate and the week-long protection of civilian side events are important avenues to discuss key issues and trends, share best practices and reflect on required policy and normative changes to ensure that civilians are protected in times of conflict. We can really do more by working hard together.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to Mr. Popowski.

Mr. Popowski: I have the honour to speak on behalf of the European Union (EU) and its member States. The candidate countries Montenegro, Serbia, Albania, Ukraine, the Republic of Moldova and Bosnia and Herzegovina; and the potential candidate country Georgia, as well as Monaco and San Marino, align themselves with this statement.

Let me start by stressing our deep concern about the number and scale of conflicts across the globe. Among others, Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine and the crisis in the Sudan have dramatically impacted the lives of millions of civilians. Those and other conflicts also impact food security, even in countries not affected by the violence. The protection of civilian infrastructure is key to ensuring food security in time of conflict. The EU remains concerned about the humanitarian consequences resulting from armed conflicts involving the use of explosive weapons in populated areas, which destroy such objects. In that regard, we

welcome the adoption of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas. The European Union recalls that full compliance with international humanitarian law remains key for the protection of civilians affected by armed conflicts, as well as for the protection of civilian infrastructure. The EU remains committed to keeping international humanitarian law at the heart of its external action by continuing to advocate for compliance with it, accountability for its violation and the systematic implementation of resolution 2417 (2018).

In addition to protecting those important principles, the EU is committed to continue its funding in response to the global food crisis. As the needs and funding gap stretches further, we call for increased contributions from other donors, including the private sector and international financial institutions. We also call for additional complementarity among humanitarian, development and peace actions to protect essential resources, address root causes and prevent the onset of humanitarian crises. In today's complex operating environment, we need to support humanitarians to stay and deliver in a principled and efficient way. On top of that, the humanitarian space for female humanitarian workers is shrinking. Afghanistan and Yemen are the most striking examples, as female humanitarian workers have been deprived from doing their jobs effectively there, resulting in limited services for women and girls. Humanitarian access is a priority for the EU. We therefore commend the work of the Secretariat, notably the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, in developing a more systematic approach to coordinate emergency relief and ensure access for the rapid provision of emergency assistance.

Persons in vulnerable situations require our particular attention. Children remain disproportionately affected by armed conflict. We have observed an alarming increase in conflict-related sexual violence against children. Attacks against schools are also on the rise. Combined with the disastrous ramifications of the economic crisis, it poses a serious threat to the right to education. The EU welcomes the efforts of United Nations Member States that have endorsed the Safe Schools Declaration. The negative impact of conflict on gender inequality also requires our attention. Women and girls often eat least and last when food is scarce, and their voices are too often silenced. Conflicts also exacerbate gender-based violence and interrupt access

to sexual and reproductive health-care services. We remain committed to providing principled humanitarian assistance to those most in need and to ensuring that the voices of all affected populations are heard. Only in that way, can aid be efficient and effective. The EU also remains committed to implementing resolution 2475 (2019) and making humanitarian aid inclusive and accessible to persons with disabilities.

Lastly, while people impacted by conflict continue to face grave risks and challenges, the European Union remains committed to support concrete actions to protect their lives and dignity.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Mexico.

Mr. De la Fuente Ramírez (Mexico) (*spoke in Spanish*): We are grateful for the very timely convening of this debate to shed light on the challenges posed by food insecurity in relation to the protection of civilians in contemporary situations. The unanimous adoption of resolution 2417 (2018), five years ago, placed the relationship between hunger and conflict at the centre of the debate. The most recent report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) on protection of civilians makes it clear that, while armed conflict remains the main cause of food insecurity, other factors often exacerbate it.

I will limit myself to discussing two of them that are of particular concern for my country.

The first is the indiscriminate use of explosive weapons that impact civilian infrastructure, contaminate agricultural land, destroy crops and seriously affect food supply. In that regard, resolution 2573 (2021) recognizes that interconnectedness can be counted among the damage caused to infrastructure and that such damage can consequently affect the provision of basic services. And it therefore reiterates the call to comply with obligations under international humanitarian law related to the protection of civilians. That call will continue to be made, and it must be strengthened through a renewed political commitment. Mexico therefore welcomes the adoption of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas, whose negotiation my country actively participated in as a member of the core group. We believe that the Declaration will be very useful in strengthening national practices for the benefit of the civilian population. We urge all States that have not yet done so to join it.

Secondly, environmental protection must be strengthened to prevent and mitigate the impact of conflicts on both food production and distribution. The General Assembly's adoption of its resolution 77/104, on the protection of the environment in relation to armed conflicts, drafted by the International Law Commission, represents a significant step forward in that regard. In addition to those I have mentioned, other relevant instruments include the Geneva Conventions and their Protocols Additional, as well as the resolutions adopted by the Security Council on the protection of civilians. In view of that progress, it is now time to implement the political commitments.

Breaking the vicious circle of conflict and food insecurity is essential for protecting the civilian population from the harmful effects of war and for punishing those responsible for using hunger as a weapon of war — which is unacceptable.

On behalf of Mexico, let me conclude by welcoming the recent renewal of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which will undoubtedly help to stabilize food prices and, above all else, to ensure that the food effectively reaches the most vulnerable populations.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Liechtenstein.

Ms. Oehri (Liechtenstein): We applaud Switzerland's long-standing and principled leadership of the protection of civilians agenda, including respect for international humanitarian law, which is of the essence for today's open debate.

International humanitarian law prohibits starvation as a method of warfare and grants special protection to objects indispensable to the survival of the civilian population, as reflected in resolution 2417 (2018), the fifth anniversary of which will be marked tomorrow. We also acknowledge the relevance in today's debate of resolution 2573 (2021), which condemns unlawful attacks against, and the misuse of, objects critical to the delivery of essential services, including food and water. International humanitarian law states clearly that such attacks on civilian infrastructure — carried out kinetically or with cyber weapons — are illegal. They are war crimes and must be investigated and prosecuted as such, including at the International Criminal Court when national judiciaries are unwilling or unable to do so themselves.

Unfortunately, food insecurity remains a major factor across many of the crises on the Security Council's agenda. The Sudan faces a severe humanitarian catastrophe, exacerbating food insecurity in a country in which 15 million people were already food insecure before the outbreak of the conflict. We join others in calling for a permanent ceasefire and respect for international humanitarian law at all times and support efforts to facilitate a dialogue that respects the peaceful democratic transition called for by the people of the Sudan in 2019, with the full, equal and meaningful participation of women.

The people of Yemen continue to face unprecedented levels of hunger, which has long been a feature of the conflict. We are grateful for the work of humanitarian organizations and support their calls for unimpeded access. We also urge the parties to the conflict to redouble their efforts and seize the opportunity for peace that has emerged in recent months.

The aggression against Ukraine, including the attacks against civilians and civilian objects, has had devastating humanitarian consequences, with 6 million people struggling to access safe drinking water and an alarming increase in food insecurity worldwide. The extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative represents a lifeline for people around the globe and demonstrates the relevance of diplomacy even in the most acute of conflicts, including when the Council is deadlocked.

Ensuring compliance with the relevant provisions of international humanitarian law and a comprehensive, impartial and sustainably funded system of international justice must remain a priority for the international community. In that regard, we are grateful for Switzerland's leadership in spearheading an amendment to the Rome Statute to include the war crime of the intentional starvation of civilians in non-international armed conflicts, and we encourage all States to join us in ratifying it.

We also encourage the Council to better acknowledge the preventive dimension of the protection of civilians agenda, including by ensuring the credible prospect of accountability for violations of international humanitarian law that are a result of cyberoperations. The report on the application of the Rome Statute to cyberwarfare that we published together with an eminent council of advisers provides relevant guidance in that regard.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Ireland.

Mr. Mythen (Ireland): I am honoured to deliver this statement on behalf of the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger, comprising the Dominican Republic, Ecuador, Estonia, France, Germany, Ireland, Mexico, the Kingdom of the Netherlands, the Niger, Norway, Sweden, Switzerland, the United Kingdom and the United States of America, and which is co-chaired this year by Ireland and Ecuador.

We would first like to thank Switzerland for convening today's important open debate, as well as all the briefers for their remarks. They have clearly outlined the devastating impact of conflict on food and nutrition.

Tomorrow we will mark five years since the Security Council unanimously adopted resolution 2417 (2018). That was a significant achievement and a clear expression of our collective political will to end conflict-induced hunger. With that landmark resolution, the Council acknowledged the undisputable link between conflict and food insecurity and condemned the use of the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare. The Group of Friends echoes the Secretary-General's recommendation to give full effect to resolution 2417 (2018). In the five years since its adoption, the urgency of the resolution has only become clearer. Nearly 258 million people, in 58 countries and territories, were experiencing acute food insecurity in 2022 — up from 193 million, in 53 countries and territories in 2021. For the vast majority of affected people, conflict is the main driver of hunger. A global crisis of such magnitude and complexity demands collective, immediate and coherent action. Today we have an opportunity to do just that. The members of the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger would like to raise three points.

First, action by the Council on conflict and hunger is essential. The Council has a responsibility to take clear and decisive action. To do so, the Council relies on timely information on the driving factors of hunger, including through white notes produced by Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, and the regular reports of the World Food Programme and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations. In that context, the Group of Friends welcomes the latest report on the protection of civilians by the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) and its emphasis on the interaction between armed conflicts and hunger

this year. The United Nations and its agencies and civil society working on the ground play a critical role in gathering empirical evidence on acute food insecurity and its impact in multiple contexts. When that information is brought to the Council's attention, it has a duty to take appropriate action.

Secondly, conflict and food insecurity are deeply connected issues. As Russia's military aggression against Ukraine has made very clear, our food systems are interconnected; conflicts in one part of the world can have knock-on effects for millions across the globe. The Black Sea Grain Initiative represents a vital effort to mitigate those impacts. We implore all the parties to continue to implement its provisions fully and to continue discussions to find sustainable solutions that allow for its effective and predictable operation.

Thirdly, the Group of Friends calls for steps to ensure accountability for attacks on civilian targets. From Haiti to Burkina Faso to the Sudan, we are witnessing how food and food supplies are being targeted in conflict, with food delivery trucks looted, farmland burned and farmers forced to flee and humanitarian aid denied to displaced populations. That is quite simply a matter of life and death. Civilians bear the burden of conflict, with women and children disproportionately affected by such flagrant violations of international humanitarian law. On the occasion of Protection of Civilians Week, we all have to recommit to ensuring accountability.

There are promising examples of actions being taken to alleviate hunger in many parts of the world, but much more needs to be done. Ultimately, humanitarian action alone cannot be the answer. Ending conflict-induced hunger requires ending conflict, and for that we require political will. And we encourage all actors to find pathways to peace that can end the suffering caused by conflict across the world. Until hunger is a thing of the past, until we have broken the vicious cycle between armed conflict and food insecurity, we must redouble our efforts. The Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger and partners will continue to keep that issue at the forefront of the Council's agenda for as long as it takes. I shall now make some brief additional remarks in my national capacity.

First, with regard to the issue of the protection of civilians, there is an obligation to protect objects indispensable to the survival of the civilian population. The Secretary-General has emphasized that the use of

explosive weapons in populated areas causes harm to civilians, harm that lasts long after their use and the conflicts themselves. For civilians in cities at war, explosive weapons threaten death, injury and disability. Equally, when critical civilian infrastructure — food, water and sanitation systems — is damaged or destroyed, the provision of the most basic human needs and essential services is disrupted. The effects can echo down generations, eroding prospects for peace, undermining respect for human rights and making the rebuilding of societies even more challenging.

We must urgently reverse that pattern. That is why Ireland led the negotiations on a political declaration to address the humanitarian consequences arising from the use of explosive weapons in populated areas. We strongly welcomed the November 2022 adoption of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas and echo the Secretary-General's call on all States to join it. It is also vital that we maintain our momentum in implementing the Declaration. The Oslo Conference will provide a critical opportunity to make progress on that objective, and Ireland offers its continued support to Norway in those efforts.

My final point concerns conflict and hunger. In spite of the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018) five years ago, we are failing to counter conflict-induced hunger. To its shame, the Council has too often turned a blind eye and shirked its responsibility. Armed conflict remains the most significant driver of acute food insecurity across the globe. That is true in the Sudan. It is true in Haiti. It is true in Somalia, Ethiopia, South Sudan, Yemen and Syria. The list goes on. Our responsibility is clear. We must urgently break the perverse cycle of conflict-induced food insecurity. Resolution 2417 (2018) gives us the tools. What we need now is the collective political will to use them. While we cannot undo the damage already done, we can ensure that the mistakes of the past do not continue to haunt our future. The Council must take concrete action and leave no stone unturned in its efforts to seek peaceful resolutions of conflicts. The lives of millions of people are at stake.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Austria.

Mr. Almoslechner (Austria): I would first like to express my gratitude to you, Mr. President, for convening today's open debate, and to the briefers

for their insightful remarks. After two years, it was good to hear once again from the Secretariat and the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) at the highest level.

Austria aligns itself with the statements delivered by the representative of the European Union and by the representative of Kuwait, speaking on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict.

Permit me to briefly address four points in my national capacity.

First, a simple rule, but one that bears repeating, is that civilians and civilian objects cannot be targets. International humanitarian law is clear and needs to be upheld by all parties to armed conflict and under all circumstances. The ICRC has a key role in that respect — working with States and non-State armed groups to disseminate international humanitarian law and seek compliance with it, including through its bilateral confidential dialogues — as does the Security Council, by condemning violations of international humanitarian law, including direct attacks on civilians and civilian objects whenever and wherever they occur, and by doing its part in ensuring accountability for them. That was why, during Austria's last membership of the Security Council, we placed particular emphasis on the protection of civilians. And it was under Austria's presidency of the Council in November 2009 that we adopted resolution 1894 (2009), on the protection of civilians in armed conflict.

Secondly, resolution 2573 (2021), on the protection of essential services, was a further step by the Security Council in its efforts to rethink the protection of civilians agenda in a holistic way. Unfortunately, however, its implementation has lagged behind. In that regard, we want to highlight once more the direct and reverberating effects of the use of explosive weapons in populated areas. When such arms are used, not only are more than 90 per cent of their casualties civilians, but they also devastate a wide range of essential services, especially water and sanitation and electricity, hampering social and economic development. The adoption of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas and its endorsement by 83 States represent a milestone. We call on all other States to endorse the Declaration and implement it faithfully in order to prevent or reduce harm to civilians, as well as protect essential services.

Thirdly, resolution 2417 (2018) was adopted five years ago and we urgently need to do better to protect civilians from conflict-induced hunger. The early-warning mechanism contained in the resolution has been used more frequently in recent years, and that is a positive. We encourage the Secretary-General to make increased use of it to enable the Council and all States to act pre-emptively. We welcome the Secretary-General's efforts to mitigate the food insecurity exacerbated by Russia's war of aggression on Ukraine, which it continues to wage in violation of the Charter of the United Nations. The Black Sea Grain Initiative has been a success story and Austria welcomed its extension last week.

My final point is that we can no longer pretend that the Security Council should not be a forum for discussing climate change. We need to face facts. Climate change exacerbates vulnerabilities and can fuel armed conflict. Climate change therefore needs to be addressed in the Chamber. We owe it to the civilians whom the Council should protect.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Croatia.

Mr. Šimonović (Croatia): I thank the Swiss Confederation for organizing today's very timely event and our briefers for their frank assessment of the dire situation.

I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, consisting of 55 member States and the European Union, this year co-chaired by Botswana, Costa Rica and Croatia.

Resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021) reiterate the primary responsibility of States to protect their populations throughout their territory and highlight the links between armed conflict and violence and conflict-induced food insecurity and the threat of famine. We would like to commend Switzerland for organizing today's important open debate to draw attention to that aspect.

All Member States have committed to the responsibility to protect their populations from genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity and ethnic cleansing. Nevertheless, today we are bearing witness to the pervasive erosion of respect for civilian lives and objects and an appalling disregard in some regions for the norms and laws that States have established to reduce the effects of armed conflict and protect

their populations from atrocity crimes. The starvation of civilians as a method of warfare is a violation of international humanitarian law and can constitute a war crime. However, in multiple conflicts, we are seeing the weaponization of access to clean water and food, which are crucial to the survival of civilian populations. Moreover, we have increasingly seen evidence of States and other parties to conflicts engaging in the denial of humanitarian access, including by blocking the passage of aid or targeting humanitarian and medical workers and assets. Such unconscionable acts have an alarming impact on the vulnerable civilian population.

Furthermore, international and intra-State conflicts have exacerbated food insecurity and malnutrition, driven up global food prices and have impacted the Organization's ability to deliver aid to the most vulnerable communities around the world.

It is in that context that the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect would like to stress the following points:

First, the Group of Friends calls on all parties to armed conflicts to allow and facilitate, in accordance with the relevant provisions of international humanitarian law and with humanitarian principles, rapid and unimpeded access to humanitarian personnel, equipment and supplies and the timely delivery of humanitarian assistance to populations in need. That means lifting arbitrary bureaucratic impediments to humanitarian operations, allowing the flow of humanitarian aid and services into conflict areas and protecting medical personnel and civilians, including humanitarian actors, from attacks.

We commend the adoption of resolution 2664 (2022) regarding humanitarian exemptions to assets freezes under United Nations sanctions regimes. When allowing and facilitating humanitarian access to all people in need in conflict settings is a matter of international peace and security, the Security Council should continue to play a constructive role in encouraging the protection of humanitarian access.

Secondly, the international community needs to urge and support States where civilians are facing conflict-induced hunger to realign spending priorities and commit resources to fulfilling the population's needs.

Globally, humanitarian needs are rising steeply. The international community should enhance its efforts to anticipate and, thus, prevent rising needs and reduce

global fragility. Providing the basic needs of people affected by crises should be a shared responsibility for all. Resource scarcity and threats to humanitarian operations increase the risk of atrocities. In order to mitigate that risk, Member States should urgently respond to the Organization's humanitarian appeals and increase predictable and flexible funding.

Thirdly, efforts to prevent atrocities and protect civilians must be responsive to demographic considerations. Security Council resolutions on women and peace and security note that armed conflicts and emergencies have a disproportionate impact on women and girls, whose rights must be respected and protected. Their needs should be considered and addressed and their full, equal, safe and meaningful participation in all processes related to peace and security promoted, including in the leadership and delivery of the humanitarian response. Gender-based discrimination and inequality, including the systematic oppression of women and girls, are important risk factors that can contribute to atrocity crimes. Addressing root causes of gender-based discrimination and violence, as well as meaningfully including and elevating women's voices on their unique experiences and needs in atrocity situations, can enhance prevention strategies. The Group urges the United Nations and other relevant actors to ensure that affected populations, including women and girls, are involved in the development, implementation and monitoring of civilian protection strategies and activities.

Lastly, the effective prevention of atrocities and the timely and efficient response to them can be strengthened if the United Nations system further improves its cross-departmental collaboration and responds holistically by using all the tools and mechanisms at its disposal, including humanitarian assistance, and ensuring that all relevant information and capacities generated by all parts of the United Nations are shared and acted upon.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Egypt.

Mr. Elshandawily (Egypt) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, allow me to thank you, Mr. President, for convening this meeting, which is particularly important in the light of the increasing number of crises in the world today, the repercussions of which mainly affect civilians. I also thank the briefers for the information shared with the Council.

This meeting is being held at a time of increasing armed conflicts and other crises that cast a shadow over the protection of civilians, pose further challenges to the application of international humanitarian law and exacerbate various repercussions such as displacement, food insecurity and impeded access to basic services, such as health care, food, water and education, thus increasing the suffering of civilians, especially women and girls.

Regrettably, the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/345) shows that the number of civilian casualties has increased as a result of the continued armed conflicts throughout the world, many of which are in the Middle East. The report highlighted that last year was the deadliest in the occupied Palestinian territories since 2005. Egypt renews its call for international protection of the Palestinian people and for immediate action to stop all violations suffered by the Palestinians, which are a flagrant breach of international humanitarian law and the legitimate rights of the Palestinian people under international law.

Egypt stresses the close link between growing hunger and food insecurity and the risk of armed conflicts worldwide, especially in States that already face multiple challenges. Accordingly, we must redouble international efforts to expeditiously achieve the second Sustainable Development Goal — to end hunger and achieve food security — especially in the light of the additional challenges in the aftermath of the coronavirus disease pandemic and other international crises that led to the unprecedented food insecurity crisis that the world is witnessing today. This threatens global instability and further crises and armed conflicts.

Accordingly, Egypt stresses the need to address the root causes of food insecurity through a comprehensive perspective that takes into consideration the need to achieve complementarity between responding to famine and providing more support to developing countries, especially those that rely on food imports and food items in order to achieve food security and promote sustainable agriculture. Egypt also notes the risks of water scarcity in a number of regions, especially North Africa, and its direct impact on agricultural activities and achieving food security, especially since a number of estimates confirm that 2.5 billion people will be affected by food scarcity and more than 700 million people will be displaced by 2030. That underscores the urgent need to strengthen effective transboundary water cooperation.

The continued armed conflicts have also led to multiple other crises related to the suspension of basic services, including health care. The Secretary-General's report notes the continued exposure of health-care workers in medical facilities to severe violations in armed conflicts, which can result in their injury or death, as well as the destruction of medical facilities, thus casting a long shadow and reducing health care. Accordingly, during its recent membership in the Security Council, Egypt worked with other members to promote resolution 2286 (2016), on the protection of health-care personnel and facilities during armed conflict. The resolution was based on existing legal norms that are binding on parties to armed conflict and called on States to adopt effective measures to protect health-care workers and to guarantee unimpeded access to medical care during armed conflict, pursuant to international humanitarian law.

The persistence of armed conflicts underscores the importance of adopting a comprehensive approach to address this serious challenge that takes into account the root causes of conflict, contributes to the long-term protection of civilians and ensures the promotion of sustainable development, growth, employment opportunities and poverty eradication, in parallel with supporting political solutions to crises so as to prevent their recurrence. Meanwhile, the increase in conflicts means that we must promote investment in national institutions relevant to addressing conflicts, supporting stability and increasing compliance with international law, especially as non-State actors are playing an increasing role in fuelling armed conflicts, targeting civilians and threatening stability and are involved in arms smuggling and other illegal activities. The aforementioned cannot be separated from the critical role of peacekeeping operations in supporting the efforts to protect civilians during armed conflict through capacity-building and support for national institutions, while respecting the principle of national ownership. Accordingly, Egypt continues to support United Nations efforts in that regard and to shoulder its responsibilities as a major troop-contributing country to peacekeeping operations, realizing the role of those missions in pushing for stability and transitioning from conflict to peace.

In conclusion, Egypt stresses the need to boost all international efforts to guarantee compliance with international humanitarian law during armed conflict and the need to work in parallel to guarantee the

prevention of conflict and address its root causes and its resolution through peaceful and effective means. Moreover, we must cooperate for the promotion of long-term growth and development activities to ensure its sustainability. Egypt will remain committed to supporting all efforts aimed at achieving peace and stability at the regional and international levels.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Pakistan.

Mr. Akram (Pakistan): Pakistan welcomes the convening of this important debate on conflict and food security by the Swiss presidency.

Today there are more than 250 million people who go to bed hungry each day. Seventy per cent of them are in areas of armed conflict. The majority of them are children.

The nexus between hunger and conflict is well established and vividly visible in so many recent and contemporary conflict situations.

The imperative of preventing, resolving and ending armed conflicts has never been so clear. Yet, new conflict situations have continued to be added to old and entrenched issues on the agenda of the Security Council; and hunger has continued to grow, with the proliferation of conflicts and other accompanying causes of poverty and deprivation which encompass almost 1 billion people — one in every eight humans — mostly in the global South.

The primary endeavour in the Security Council and other global forums must remain the promotion and maintenance of peace and security and the resolution of conflicts and disputes in accordance with the principles of the Charter of the United Nations.

Speaking for my own region, the key to securing peace and stability in South Asia is the just and early resolution of the Jammu and Kashmir dispute in accordance with the provisions of the relevant Security Council resolutions. Deprivation and hunger are being imposed on the Kashmiri people by a 900,000-strong occupation army, massive violations of their human rights and the progressive expropriation of their properties and means of livelihood. It is therefore sad to see some, but not all, of the Group of 20 representatives allow themselves to be used in India's attempt to portray a false sense of normalcy in occupied Jammu and Kashmir. The Human Rights Council's Special Rapporteur on minority issues,

Mr. Fernand de Varennes, warned on 15 May of that attempt to normalize military occupation. He said, “the situation in Jammu and Kashmir should be decried and condemned, not pushed under the rug”.

The consequences of 40 years of conflict are also writ large in Afghanistan. Almost 95 per cent of Afghanistan’s population exists in extreme poverty. Even as we seek to ensure women’s rights and end terrorism in and from Afghanistan the world cannot allow the Afghan people to be consigned to prolonged poverty. The Secretary-General’s humanitarian appeal for Afghanistan should be fully funded. The Afghan economy must be rapidly revived through the release of Afghanistan’s assets abroad, its banking system revived, reconstruction of its infrastructure resumed and the agreed connectivity projects implemented.

Pakistan commends the Secretary-General’s Black Sea Grain Initiative to ease the impact of the Ukraine war and accompanying restrictions on food security. We hope that agreement will be implemented faithfully and fully. Above all, Pakistan desires an early end of the war in Ukraine in accordance with the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and international agreements.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Rwanda.

Mr. Gatete (Rwanda): Allow me to start by congratulating you, Mr. President, on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of May. Let me also take this opportunity to thank all the briefers for their insightful contributions to the debate.

This briefing comes at a time of heightened and erupting conflicts around the world. While the United Nations and Member States are occupied with the resolution, the mitigation and the management of those conflicts, we must remember that our primary responsibility is the protection of innocent civilians caught up in the middle.

Not only is conflict deadly to civilians, but it also strips victims and survivors of their humanity, their livelihood and their dignity. Unfortunately, civilians are increasingly subject to conflict and atrocities even though international humanitarian law dictates that all States must protect civilians in conflicts.

It makes matters worse when the Security Council, States and parties to conflict take more time with attempts at resolutions and intervention. That delays

humanitarian aid, leaving civilians displaced, hungry or purposely starved. More effort should instead be put into efficiently and urgently providing protection to civilians and making way for humanitarian aid.

Allow me to offer our thoughts.

First, to promote a more systematic implementation of existing frameworks and instruments for the protection of civilians, the Security Council must first commit to an honest appraisal of the current mechanisms. That involves acknowledging gaps in implementation and proposing practical solutions that cater to respective conflicts. For instance, a more rigorous monitoring and evaluation system could be established to gauge the efficiency and effectiveness of those mechanisms and resolutions. In addition, promoting dialogue and sharing best practices among Member States is critical.

Secondly, the survival and dignity of the civilian population during armed conflict can be ensured through a combination of measures. Challenges include maintaining the neutrality of humanitarian aid, ensuring safe and unimpeded access to conflict zones and protecting aid workers.

The use of early warning systems can alert populations to immediate danger while resilience-building initiatives can equip communities with the tools to withstand shocks.

According to the World Food Programme, over 70 per cent of hunger-affected populations live in conflict zones. There needs to be a solid ecosystem where the supply and distribution of food and essentials for survival are timely and consistent.

Thirdly, women play a vital role as caregivers and leaders in their communities, making their contributions essential in addressing food insecurity and protecting essential services. In the words of Ms. Michelle Bachelet, former President of Chile and United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights,

“A full understanding of women’s experience of conflict is critical for inclusive responses and for promoting an enabling environment for women and girls in all their diversity to thrive and meaningfully participate in peace processes, peacebuilding, and recovery efforts.”

Fourthly and finally, Member States, the United Nations system, the Red Cross, regional organizations and civil society organizations each have unique roles

to play in ensuring the implementation of international humanitarian law. These organizations and Member States can also strengthen their partnerships and increase coordination to tackle food insecurity and the protection of essential services. For instance, civil society organizations on the ground can provide real-time insights into local needs, while regional organizations can use their influence to promote peaceful conflict resolution. These combined efforts will protect facilities that are indispensable for the civilian population's survival.

As I conclude, let me reiterate that the primary role of the Security Council is the protection of civilians in conflict. This responsibility falls upon all of us legally and morally. It is unfortunate that situations can worsen while we spend more time focusing on debates and resolutions instead of urgently putting measures in place to adequately protect civilians and create corridors for humanitarian aid. The Security Council and its members should revise how protection and humanitarian intervention are approached. However, what should remain constant in intervention is a swift response.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Poland.

Mr. Szczerski (Poland): Let me begin by thanking Switzerland for organizing this important debate and by expressing my appreciation to all briefers and the Secretary-General for their contributions.

We believe that the strong focus on conflict-induced food insecurity and the protection of critical civilian infrastructure and essential services is now of crucial importance. Before I delve into the details, I would like to emphasize once again that civilians and civilian infrastructure during armed conflict are protected under international humanitarian law. Therefore, attacks targeting civilians and objects indispensable to the survival of civilians constitute war crimes, and their perpetrators should be held accountable. The international community should take a firm stance against this problem. Bearing that in mind, I would like to address four points.

First, Poland highly values resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021). We call for their full implementation, as, in our view, doing so could limit the risk of conflict-induced famine and food insecurity, ensure better protection of civilian infrastructure and lead to the establishment of durable humanitarian pauses to facilitate assistance in conflict-affected areas.

Secondly, Poland stresses the importance of investing in reliable, sustainable and resilient infrastructure as an essential condition for securing the well-being and safety of civilian populations facing armed conflicts. In the General Assembly resolution initiated by Poland and adopted just recently (General Assembly resolution 77/282), the Assembly emphasized the critical role of infrastructure systems in safeguarding the delivery of essential goods and services.

Thirdly, we underline that the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development sets out essential preconditions for lasting peace and stability. It is vital to get back on track with the implementation of the 2030 Agenda, in particular with regard to food security and access to essential services, so as to mitigate and end conflicts, rebuild institutions and infrastructure and provide for well-being and respect for human rights for individuals and societies.

Fourthly, Poland supports efforts aimed at ensuring compliance with international humanitarian law by all parties to armed conflicts and would like to see the Security Council take concrete measures in this regard. The international community's unity on the unconditional respect for international humanitarian law should be strengthened. Particular responsibility for the respect of the United Nations Charter and international law lies with the permanent members of the Security Council. Poland would welcome joint efforts to hold all perpetrators accountable for serious violations of humanitarian law and the Geneva Conventions.

At this point we need to keep repeating the following question: how do we make the Security Council fulfil the purpose for which it was created when one of its permanent members shows an absolute disregard for the basic provisions of international humanitarian law? Russia's aggression against Ukraine is an example of weaponizing food and food production, in violation of resolution 2417 (2018), which condemns the use of food insecurity and starvation as a military tactic.

As was emphasized by the President of the Republic of Poland at the general debate of the seventy-seventh session of the General Assembly,

"From the very beginning of the invasion, Russia has been deliberately and cynically destroying new crops and farming equipment, and the invasion itself has drastically reduced Ukrainian harvests...

“Who will suffer from that? It will be those who are most in need. It is an economic weapon; it is the weaponization of food” (A/77/PV.5, p.28).

Although we welcome prolongation of the Black Sea Grain Initiative and hope its implementation will benefit many civilians who depend on grain from Ukraine, we believe that only by ending the Russian aggression and unblocking all Ukrainian ports on the Black Sea coast will the export of grains from Ukraine be ensured and the balance in the global food markets restored. In this context, the clearance of explosives in the contaminated areas, including agriculture lands in various regions of Ukraine, poses a big challenge.

Poland continues its efforts to address effects of war hostilities on civilians, food systems, energy infrastructure and displacement. We are helping Ukraine, continuing our humanitarian projects in Middle East and responding to other crises around the world. Poland continues its assistance to partners from the Middle East that are affected by the consequences of the refugee crisis caused by the war in Syria. Poland will also continue to support populations of countries affected by long-term crises, particularly those at risk of famine, such as Yemen, Syria and Afghanistan.

As in previous years, Poland will also continue to support those most in need through voluntary financial contributions to international organizations. In recent years Poland has financially supported the activities of the World Food Programme in Afghanistan, Tajikistan, Syria, Kenya, Lebanon and Yemen. In 2022, we contributed \$1 million to ease the food-security crisis suffered by a number of African countries. We stand in solidarity with countries and communities particularly affected by the Russian aggression against Ukraine.

Although today’s debate focuses on food insecurity, it also coincides with the seventh anniversary of the unanimous adoption of resolution 2286 (2016) on the protection of health care in conflict. The gap between the principles of international humanitarian law and reality is expanding. We therefore need to enhance our support and advocacy towards full compliance with international humanitarian law obligations that protect the wounded and sick, medical personnel and humanitarian personnel exclusively engaged in medical duties.

In conclusion, let me emphasize that the protection of civilians and the promotion of compliance with international humanitarian law have been long-standing

priorities for Poland. We remain committed to doing our part and to contributing to initiatives and activities aimed at the protection of civilians in armed conflict.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Algeria.

Mr. Gaouaoui (Algeria): I would like to commend Switzerland on its successful presidency of the Security Council this month and wish the Swiss delegation further success in the remaining period.

As Council members may be aware, Algeria contributed to the very inception of international humanitarian law. Henry Dunant was living in Algeria when he travelled to witness the horror of the battle of Solferino and decided to create the first humanitarian organization. Emir Abdelkader inspired the core rules that codified international humanitarian law, in particular through the respect he showed in the treatment of prisoners and in the distinction he made between combatants and non-combatants.

International humanitarian law must be respected by all, under all circumstances. No compromises are allowed in this regard.

Algeria is alarmed by the rise of the level of acute food insecurity around the world. My country calls for strengthening international cooperation and solidarity so as to face the scourge of hunger and food insecurity and address their root causes, in particular, underdevelopment. Moreover, humanitarian assistance is crucial in the context of humanitarian emergencies. We appeal for a smooth transition from relief to development that takes into account the priorities of the affected countries and the host communities that bear most of the burden. We also stress the need to provide humanitarian assistance in line with humanitarian principles, as stated in General Assembly resolution 46/182. Furthermore, obstructing or targeting aid workers is completely unacceptable. We condemn any act of that kind and call for ensuring protection and accountability.

In commenting and interacting with the concept note prepared for today’s discussion (S/2023/307, annex), I would like to share the following points.

First, the effective implementation of Security Council resolutions, including resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), is key to preserving the safety and security of United Nations and humanitarian personnel

in armed conflict situations. The Security Council must shoulder its responsibility for the implementation of and respect for its resolutions.

Secondly, accountability is a key element to guarantee full respect for international humanitarian law. In that regard, legal frameworks should be reinforced, thereby ensuring that all persons who commit violations are brought to justice with an effective zero-tolerance policy.

Thirdly, coordination with national authorities is crucial in addressing food insecurity. We call for the alignment of humanitarian and development assistance with national development priorities and strategies to better address the food insecurity issue.

Fourthly, strengthening cooperation and further involving regional and subregional organizations will contribute to achieving significant progress in ending hunger, food insecurity and all forms of malnutrition.

Fifthly, the Security Council should enhance its collaboration and cooperation with other United Nations bodies and agencies such as the General Assembly, the Economic and Social Council and the Food and Agriculture Organization. Despite the impact conflicts may have on food security, the latter remains a development issue that requires a development-centred approach.

We all agree that it is unacceptable for people to die of hunger in this day and age. We must therefore redouble our efforts to end hunger and food insecurity, especially by implementing the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Ms. Ershadi (Islamic Republic of Iran): We commend Switzerland's presidency for initiating this open debate, and we thank the Secretary-General and the other briefers for their incisive briefings.

Protecting civilians during conflict is critical, as it has a devastating impact on their lives. Under international humanitarian law, all parties to a conflict are required to ensure that civilians have access to essential goods and services, including food and medical care. They are also prohibited from attacking civilian objects such as food supplies, water sources and hospitals.

Despite the obligations outlined in international humanitarian law, the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) indicates that armed conflicts in 2022 resulted in a significant number of casualties, including deaths, injuries, enforced disappearances and immense suffering. The United Nations documented a concerning increase in civilian deaths, with at least 16,988 recorded across 12 conflicts, marking a 53 per cent rise compared to the previous year.

The report also highpoints the persistent and devastating effects of armed conflicts on food security, leading to continued hunger in many regions. The disruption of agriculture and trade exacerbates the situation, causing shortages of essential supplies and agricultural products. Those alarming statistics underline the urgent need for concrete efforts to address the impact of armed conflicts on food security and to protect civilian populations.

Yet in the Middle East — our critical region — terrorism, occupation, illegal unilateral acts and the presence of illegal foreign forces continue to wreak havoc on civilians and their infrastructure.

In the occupied Palestinian territory, the Israeli regime continues its oppressive, expansionist and apartheid practices, systematically violating the human rights of Palestinians. The Secretary-General's report underlines that last year witnessed the highest number of Palestinian civilian fatalities in the West Bank since 2005. Furthermore, the situation in Gaza is deeply distressing, as it has effectively become the world's largest prison. The destruction of vital infrastructure compounds the already dire humanitarian situation, leaving the people of Gaza in a state of extreme vulnerability.

In the Syrian Arab Republic, the persistence of unilateral sanctions imposed by the United States and the European Union, as well as the plundering of Syrian natural resources by illegal foreign forces, have had a negative impact on the humanitarian situation in Syria, exacerbating the challenges faced by the Syrian people and impeding the Syrian Government's ability to provide essential services to those in need. Furthermore, the Israeli regime continues its aggressions and terrorist attacks against Syria's sovereignty and territorial integrity with impunity and no repercussions from the international community. We strongly condemn those heinous crimes, as they target civilian infrastructure and violate international humanitarian law and the Charter of the United Nations, posing a severe threat to regional peace and stability.

In Afghanistan, to ensure that the Afghan people receive the assistance they require, humanitarian aid must remain impartial and unconditional. Any politicization of humanitarian assistance will only harm the Afghan people, who rely on such assistance for their survival. Likewise, the frozen assets of the Afghan people must be returned in full and without any conditions. Meanwhile, the *de facto* authorities must fulfil their commitments, particularly those concerning the rights of women and girls.

To provide effective civilian protection, it is critical to prioritize ending the conflict and securing a political solution, in addition to scaling up humanitarian operations. Effective humanitarian operations for civilian protection rely on international cooperation, proper and timely financing and access to resources. Unfortunately, those elements are impeded by unilateral coercive measures.

Unilateral coercive measures have severe consequences, particularly for food insecurity, affecting civilians, especially women, and children. Those illegal measures also hamper health-care systems and humanitarian organizations, restricting access to medical supplies and impeding aid delivery. By lifting unilateral sanctions, the international community can foster an environment that enables swift and effective humanitarian responses, ensuring that critical assistance reaches those in need without unnecessary delays or limitations.

Finally, we urge all parties to armed conflicts to fully comply with their obligations under international law, as well as to respect the humanitarian principles of humanity, neutrality, impartiality and independence in the provision of humanitarian assistance, including medical assistance.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Türkiye.

Mrs. Özgür (Türkiye): We would like to express our appreciation to Switzerland for convening this important annual debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict. This year's theme could not be more relevant nor timelier, given the scale of the grievances caused by hunger and food insecurity in various parts of the world in recent years.

First of all, it should be noted that conflicts continue to pose major threats to global food security. The situation has been further aggravated

by the coronavirus disease pandemic, disruptions in agricultural production and supply chains, and extreme climate events.

The international community should take urgent steps to break the vicious cycle between armed conflict and food security. As a leading country in the humanitarian field, Türkiye continues to do its part to alleviate the human suffering caused by this cycle. The Black Sea Grain Initiative has been a landmark achievement in easing the pressure of food insecurity for millions of people and reducing global food prices. The Initiative has thus far facilitated the safe export of over 30 million metric tons of grain and foodstuffs from Ukraine. We will continue to support the Secretary-General's efforts and work closely with the parties for the full implementation of the deal to help people in need in different parts of the world.

In Syria, we are also pleased to be cooperating with the United Nations on delivering life-saving humanitarian assistance to millions of vulnerable people through the United Nations cross-border aid mechanism. Food security and nutrition, as well as protection, are at the forefront of that assistance. The devastating earthquakes that hit Türkiye and Syria in February have further exacerbated the humanitarian situation in Syria, especially in the north-west. Ensuring the uninterrupted delivery of cross-border humanitarian aid to Syria is more critical than ever. We will continue to work in close dialogue with all parties to extend the Security Council's authorization in July. The need for the protection of Palestinian civilians also remains an imperative task facing the United Nations. It is deeply concerning that the operations of the World Food Programme in Palestine risk being suspended owing to a funding shortfall. It is a disgrace that even the symptoms of the longest-standing conflict on the United Nations agenda cannot be cured, let alone its root causes.

In the face of the ongoing threats to international peace and security, primarily the expanded scale and scope of armed conflicts, we should update our conventional approaches and double our efforts to protect civilians, especially women and children, who bear the brunt of conflict. The protection of civilians was recognized as a matter of international peace and security nearly 25 years ago by the Security Council. However, the global track record shows that in a quarter of a century we should have done better. We therefore urge everyone, and the Security Council most of all, to

utilize the normative framework built up over the years, punish serious violations of international law and keep prevention and addressing the root causes of conflicts at the top of our agenda.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Germany.

Ms. Leendertse (Germany): I thank, you, Sir, for convening this important debate, and my delegation is also grateful for the insights provided by the briefers this morning.

Germany aligns itself with the statement made by the Director-General for General European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations of the European Commission on behalf of the European Union, and the statements by the representatives of Ireland, Kuwait and Croatia on behalf of the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger, the Group of Friends of the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, respectively.

In 2018 the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018), on conflict and hunger, raised high hopes. However, on its fifth anniversary, there is little reason to celebrate. Acute food insecurity has reached unprecedented levels, affecting a record number of almost 350 million people — up from 135 million in 2019. The effects of Russia's devastating war of aggression against Ukraine on food and fertilizer prices, the climate and biodiversity crises and other factors therefore now make for a dangerous combination. I would like to make three points in that context.

First, we already have strong instruments for ensuring the protection of civilians in armed conflict. They are international humanitarian law and international human rights law. However, those universal rules are infringed on far too often. A just and effective multilateral system requires us to condemn such acts and hold their perpetrators accountable through international criminal justice mechanisms, but also politically, here in the Security Council and the General Assembly. The Call for Action to strengthen respect for international humanitarian law and principled humanitarian action, initiated by Germany and France in 2019, has become a strong reference document for our efforts to promote universal adherence to international humanitarian law. Its signatories share a priority, that of preserving the humanitarian space and ensuring access to people in need. To date, the Call for Action has been signed by 52 States, and it is still open for more signatures. I hope that many in this Chamber will join us.

Secondly, we must become better at implementing the existing instruments for the protection of civilians and providing essential services. The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, peacekeeping missions and non-governmental organizations should therefore continually monitor and report incidents. We also need to identify and fill existing gaps. The number of civilians killed or injured by bombing and shelling in urban areas last year soared by 83 per cent. Germany therefore urges Member States to join the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas and commit to a substantive follow-up process.

Thirdly, we urgently need to increase the resilience and sustainability of agriculture and food systems and invest in preparedness. Germany believes that structural reform of our global food systems, including supply chains and trade restrictions, as well as the financial architecture supporting them, is vital. Building on the Uniting for Global Food Security conference held in Berlin on 24 June of last year, the Global Alliance for Food Security, established during the German presidency of the Group of Seven, recently began its in-country engagements. Through them, we support our partners to develop measures that make their agriculture and food systems more resilient and sustainable. Germany also actively promotes gender-sensitive approaches. Addressing the root causes of gender inequalities is critical to ensuring more effective protection as well as equitable access to the instruments for achieving food security.

Germany will continue to support efforts to prevent and resolve conflicts, promote respect for international humanitarian law and provide humanitarian assistance and protection to those affected by conflict. We call on all States Members of the United Nations, and especially the Security Council, to work together to achieve the goals and ensure that the protection of civilians remains at the forefront of our collective efforts.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Georgia.

Mr. Abesadze (Georgia): At the outset, I would like to thank the presidency of Switzerland for convening this important debate and to welcome the focus of today's discussion.

Georgia aligns itself with the statement delivered earlier on behalf of the European Union, and I would like to make some additional comments in my national capacity.

The landmark resolution 2417 (2018), which for the first time addressed the link between conflict and hunger, represents an important step towards preventing food insecurity and addressing the humanitarian needs of the millions of civilians trapped in conflict-affected areas. International humanitarian law complements human rights norms on the right to adequate food by prohibiting certain kinds of behaviour in order to prevent food shortages or denials of access to food in situations of armed conflict. Unfortunately, we have witnessed a complete disregard for international humanitarian law by Russia during its war of aggression on Ukraine, which we condemn in the strongest terms.

According to the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, between 702 and 828 million people in the world may have faced hunger in 2021, and nearly 30 per cent of the global population lacked access to adequate food supplies. The outlook has been even grimmer since Russia's ongoing, premeditated, unprovoked and unjustified aggression against Ukraine, which has driven global food and fertilizer prices even higher. To that end, we welcome the extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative for two additional months. However, we can see how fragile the Initiative is, since as it is its wont, Russia is using that important agreement as another tool for putting pressure on the international community.

The four 1949 Geneva Conventions and all their Protocols Additional are part of Georgia's domestic legislation. Georgia's Interagency Coordinating Commission on International Humanitarian Law, a standing governmental body, leads efforts and coordinates the work of relevant entities aimed at ensuring respect for international humanitarian law. Among its main priorities is the implementation of international humanitarian law programmes and educational activities, in cooperation with the International Committee of the Red Cross. Most of the educational and training programmes provided to Georgia's military personnel incorporate special courses on international humanitarian law, including the key aspects of strengthening the protection of civilians during armed conflict.

However, despite the determination of the Government of Georgia to protect its population following Russia's full-scale military aggression against Georgia in August 2008, we have continued to be prevented from extending protection to the people residing in the Russian-occupied regions of Georgia — Abkhazia and Tskhinvali — who have been deprived of minimal safeguards for their security and continue to suffer from ever-increasing human rights violations, including kidnappings, arbitrary detentions, torture, ill-treatment, the deprivation of life, infringements on the right to property, violations of their right to health, restrictions on education in their native language and ethnic discrimination.

The date 19 May marked the tragic seventh anniversary of the chasing and brutal murder of a Georgian citizen, Giga Otkhozoria, by Russia's occupation regime in the Abkhazia region, but the perpetrator is still at large. We have witnessed other tragic consequences of detentions and kidnappings as well. As we speak, Georgian citizens remain in lengthy illegal detention in both regions occupied by Russia. Russia's pattern of behaviour, its ongoing illegal occupation of both Georgian regions and steps towards their factual annexation brazenly undermine the fundamental principles of international law and poses a grave threat to peace and security in the region and beyond.

In conclusion, let me reiterate our full support for the international community's endeavour to strengthen the protection of human rights of the civilian population in armed conflicts. Georgia stands ready to contribute to those efforts.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Latvia.

Mr. Pildegovičs (Latvia): Let me start by thanking Switzerland for organizing today's open debate and the Secretary-General and the briefers for their statements.

Latvia aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union.

I would like to note that as a consequence of the more than 100 armed conflicts worldwide, civilians continue to endure injury, enforced disappearance, torture, rape, death and other suffering. That is accompanied by the increase in prices of food, fuel and other critical items, the negative effects of climate change, the destruction of civilian infrastructure and

exacerbated socioeconomic vulnerabilities. The recent report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians in armed conflict (S/2023/345) outlines that grim reality and the fact that armed conflicts continue to be a primary driver of hunger. It is our joint duty to ensure a lifeline for civilians in armed conflicts to access food and essential services. The joint report by the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations and the World Food Programme, entitled “Monitoring food security in countries with conflict situations”, has listed Afghanistan, Ethiopia, Haiti, Nigeria, South Sudan, Somalia and Yemen as hunger hotspots of the highest concern, with populations facing or projected to face starvation or at risk of deterioration towards catastrophic conditions, as they already face critical food insecurity.

Russia’s aggression against Ukraine also demonstrates the connection between war, food insecurity and critical civilian infrastructure. Russia has systematically targeted water systems, the agricultural sector and electrical plants and interrupted power, heating, health care, the drinking water supply and communications services in Ukraine. Those attacks have resulted in significant civilian casualties and growing food insecurity across the globe and have denied access to essential services, including those provided by humanitarian aid workers.

We are appalled by the recent reports by the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights regarding the possible execution in March 2022 of more than 500 hundred civilians by Malian troops and foreign military personnel in Mali. There are numerous reports of the involvement of Russia’s military Wagner Group in crimes against humanity in Mali, the Central African Republic and other countries, which also corresponds to inhumane conduct by the Wagner Group mercenaries in Syria and Ukraine. It is paramount to ensure that all such crimes are being thoroughly investigated and all perpetrators are held accountable.

We have to pay special attention to the vulnerable groups. In Ukraine and elsewhere, forcibly displaced women and girls continuously face an increased risk of gender-based and sexual violence. The reported forced deportations and transfers of unaccompanied children by Russia account to war crimes. Many persons with disabilities have been unable to access food, medical services and other types of humanitarian assistance. Since the very first days of Russia’s war against Ukraine,

Latvia rapidly allocated funds for the physical and emotional rehabilitation of war victims, with a special focus on women and girls who have suffered from the sexual violence committed by Russian soldiers.

In that context, we highly value the work of the United Nations and its agencies in their efforts to provide humanitarian aid to people in Ukraine and across the world. We are deeply concerned about the fact that the space for female humanitarian workers is rapidly shrinking, with Afghanistan and Yemen being stark examples of that. In addition, we strongly condemn the increasing attacks on humanitarian workers and assets. Those acts should be stopped immediately, and all perpetrators must be held accountable.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Viet Nam.

Mr. Dang (Viet Nam): We thank Switzerland for convening today’s open debate and welcome the Security Council’s continued attention to the protection of civilians in armed conflict.

It can be observed from our own experience that although the immediate impacts of conflicts are often measured by the number of direct victims of violence, it is the widespread damage to basic infrastructure and services that has long-term consequences, especially for women and children. Driven by that grave concern, during our presidency of the Security Council in April 2021, Viet Nam worked closely with other Council members for the unanimous adoption of resolution 2573 (2021), the first resolution of its kind on the protection of objects indispensable to the survival of the civilian population in conflict areas. Unfortunately, ongoing armed conflicts continue to cause damage to critical infrastructure and residential communities, disrupting essential water, sanitation and health services, fuelling hunger and forced displacement and compounding the spread of infectious diseases. The problems lie not only in the absence of regulations, but rather in the failure to adhere to the established rules governing the conduct of parties engaged in armed conflicts.

Viet Nam therefore calls on all parties to abide by international humanitarian law, including resolution 2573 (2021). Civilian safety and their means of survival must not be held hostage by any party in armed conflict. Food, water supply and resources and related facilities must not be used in any way as tools to gain military and strategic advantages. Parties to armed conflicts bear the primary responsibility for safeguarding civilians and

civilian objects under their authority, and devastating consequences could be averted if they upheld their obligations under international humanitarian law.

The Security Council, with its primary responsibility endowed by the Charter of the United Nations to maintain international peace and security, must condemn indiscriminate or disproportionate attacks against indispensable civilian objects and adopt the measures necessary to address those violations. The General Assembly, within its relevant mandate under the Charter, needs to redouble its efforts to strengthen the international humanitarian law system. The United Nations should encourage and facilitate closer coordination between Member States, international organizations and humanitarian and development partners, both in conflict resolution and post-conflict peacebuilding, to support recovery and build resilience for civilians.

To conclude, my delegation would like to reiterate that the best way to protect civilians is to prevent conflict and address its root causes. Peace to us, as politicians, may mean many different things, but for civilians, it takes shape in the most fundamental things: food, water, shelter, health care and education. Viet Nam strongly believes that only by working together to uphold the Charter and international law can we put an end to the devastation caused by armed conflicts to the civilian population and create a foundation for sustainable peace, security and development.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Sierra Leone.

Mr. Sowa (Sierra Leone): It is my singular honour to join the discourse today to address the Security Council at this high-level open debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict on the theme of ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in conflict and addressing food insecurity and protecting essential services. At the outset, let me commend you, Mr. President, for the way in which Switzerland has conducted the affairs of the presidency of the Security Council so far, and thank you for convening today's timely debate. We would also like to thank the Secretary-General and our other briefers for their insights earlier today.

The protection of civilians in armed conflict is a fundamental principle of international humanitarian law. It is enshrined in the Geneva Conventions and the Protocols Additional, as well as in customary

international law. The principle requires all parties to an armed conflict to take every possible concrete measure to protect civilians from the effects of hostilities. Despite that, civilians continue to be victims of armed conflict. In 2022 alone, the United Nations recorded more than 10,000 civilian casualties in armed conflict.

The United Nations in general, and the Security Council in particular, have a responsibility to protect civilians in armed conflict. That responsibility can be fulfilled through a number of measures, including ensuring that all parties to armed conflict respect international humanitarian law, providing humanitarian assistance to civilians affected by armed conflict and holding the perpetrators of war crimes and other serious violations of international humanitarian law accountable. The protection of civilians in armed conflict is a complex and challenging issue. However, it is one that the United Nations must continue to work on to ensure that civilians do not become victims of armed conflict. In addition to the protection of civilians from the effects of hostilities, the United Nations system and the wider international community must also ensure their security and welfare in conflict. That includes ensuring that they have access to water, food, shelter and health care. It also includes protecting them from sexual violence and other forms of gender-based violence.

We are in an unprecedented and critical stage of a global food crisis. The current food crisis is probably the worst in a decade, and with the effects of climate change coinciding with trade restrictions and conflicts, years of progress in the battle against hunger and poverty are being rapidly reversed. Food insecurity and its consequences are more prevalent in countries affected by conflict or disasters, and there can therefore be no gainsaying that food security is a critical issue for peace and security. In May of 2022, the Secretary-General told the Security Council that "[w]hen war is waged, people go hungry" (S/PV.9036, p.2). And he also affirmed that feeding the hungry is an investment in global peace and security. There is a heightened level of food insecurity globally and Africa has been very seriously affected because conflict and general insecurity, as well as natural disasters, continue to plague the continent.

Access to quality, nutritious food is fundamental to human existence. Hunger and health are deeply connected. For children, food insecurity is particularly devastating. A lack of nutritious food can have serious implications for a child's physical and mental health.

The right to food is therefore a fundamental human right, recognized under international law. The issue of food insecurity is also a major concern in conflict-affected areas. In many cases, armed conflict disrupts agricultural production and distribution, leading to food shortages and malnutrition. The United Nations system, including the Food and Agriculture Organization and the World Food Programme, must provide food assistance to civilians in need and work to address the root causes of food insecurity in conflict-affected areas. Africa is experiencing one of the most alarming food crises in decades. Millions of people are suffering from acute food insecurity and require urgent humanitarian assistance. We have an emergency at hand. There is slow progress in achieving the goal of halving world hunger, particularly in Africa. Sierra Leone believes that there is still much to be done by all the relevant stakeholders at the national, subregional, regional and global levels to fight food insecurity and protect the lives, livelihoods and prospects of millions of people.

There is an urgent need to plan properly for structural changes to global food systems, and those plans should be rooted in sustainable food and agricultural practices. Increasing food production and distribution, reducing energy consumption and increasing energy efficiency, expanding access to finance for developing countries and dealing with the root causes of crises such as those of climate change and conflict should be at the heart of addressing the issue of food insecurity. My delegation would therefore like to reiterate the urgent call on Member States to join the growing efforts with the Global Crisis Response Group on Food Energy and Finance initiated by the Secretary-General, so that with our concerted efforts and unwavering commitment we will be able to effectively remedy that global menace.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Indonesia.

Mr. Prabowo (Indonesia): I thank Switzerland for convening today's meeting. I also thank the Secretary-General and the briefers for their insights.

The Secretary-General's most recent report on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345) presents us with a bleak reality, which is that armed conflicts have been the most significant drivers of the food insecurity that has affected approximately 117 million people in 19 countries and territories. If that issue remains unresolved, it could lead to a vicious circle. Prolonged

conflicts continue to disrupt food systems and essential services, while a lack of access to food and essential services leads to further violence. On that note, allow me to share some pertinent points.

First, starvation should never be used as a weapon of war. The Security Council can promote and enforce norms for all the parties involved in a conflict to ensure food security and the protection of essential services. Those norms can prevent situations in many conflict areas where agricultural sectors are damaged, often intentionally, driving people to leave their land and withering any hope for peace. They can also prevent situations where access to basic necessities is obstructed, such as in the occupied Palestinian territory.

Secondly, addressing food insecurity and conflicts requires a comprehensive approach. That includes promoting respect for human rights and international humanitarian law, restoring and securing access to food, promoting peaceful conflict resolution and investing in sustainable agriculture and food systems as part of peacebuilding efforts. Conflict prevention and peacekeeping must connect in a meaningful way with peacebuilding and sustainable development.

Thirdly, we must prevent a cascading impact of conflicts on global food security. Indonesia applauds the continued efforts of the Secretary-General and related parties in ensuring a resumption of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, as well as the implementation of the memorandum of understanding on trade facilitation. Both initiatives have helped to stabilize the global market, allowing the distribution of grain and fertilizer to resume and thereby staving off hunger that could affect millions. Nevertheless, a real solution can be achieved only when peace prevails.

Finally, we must embed the protection of civilians, including from hunger, into the peace continuum. The United Nations and the Council should be able to facilitate measures to strengthen countries' capacities to protect civilians, sustain peace and ensure the continuity of economic activities, food availability and the resilience of food systems. In achieving those goals, we also need to guarantee safe, unhindered, unimpeded and sustained humanitarian access in conflict areas.

Addressing hunger and famine in conflict areas demands that all members of the international community work hand in hand. No one should be left behind. Indonesia stands ready to contribute.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Norway.

Ms. Juul (Norway): I have the honour to speak on behalf of the Global Alliance for the Missing, a cross-regional group of States consisting of Argentina, Azerbaijan, Colombia, Croatia, Estonia, Kuwait, Mexico, Nigeria, Peru, the Republic of Korea, Switzerland and my own country, Norway.

The group was created in 2021 to focus attention on the issue of missing persons — a global humanitarian and human rights tragedy — and to promote the implementation of relevant obligations and commitments. This year's report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345) highlights the vast numbers of people who went missing last year due to armed conflict, continuing a worrisome trend of previous years and decades. It also highlights initiatives to prevent and address their fate. The Global Alliance welcomed the report's recommendation to

“put in place legal, policy and institutional frameworks that account for protected persons ... and ensure the effective search for and identification of missing persons and the proper management of the dead” (S/2023/345, *para. 90 (d)*).

However, there is no doubt that the ever-increasing number of missing persons far outpaces efforts to address this issue. Many members of the Global Alliance know first-hand about the challenges in providing answers to the families of the missing, some of whom have been waiting for decades. That requires political will and access to information, including archives, as well as resources and expertise.

Four years ago, the Security Council adopted resolution 2474 (2019) on missing persons in armed conflict. The resolution outlines measures to prevent and address the issue and reaffirms critical obligations under international humanitarian law, such as those set forth in the 1949 Geneva Conventions and their Protocols Additional of 1977. Notwithstanding that important achievement, the fate of missing persons and their families' needs remains all-too-often ignored, with potential long-term consequences for sustainable peace. Greater efforts by the United Nations and its Members States to implement resolution 2474 (2019) are therefore needed.

As the Global Alliance, we intend to highlight key areas where progress can and should be made, for example on the link between missing persons and peace

processes or on the creation of national mechanisms to determine their fate and whereabouts. Addressing the issue of missing persons is an essential element of international humanitarian law. Global Alliance members stand ready to share their experience and to work with others towards a more effective response at global, regional and national levels.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Thailand.

Mr. Chindawongse (Thailand): I wish to begin by commending Switzerland for organizing this important open debate on food insecurity and essential services, as they relate to the security of civilians in conflict, and to congratulate His Excellency President Alain Berset for presiding over this event. I also wish to thank the Secretary-General and all the briefers for their insightful views.

As the President mentioned this morning, the common denominator of conflicts, unfortunately, is the suffering of civilians. Conflict is terrible; its devastating impacts on innocent civilians are even more so. That is why it is so important to promote ways to minimize the impact of conflict on civilians, with a strong focus on addressing food insecurity and promoting human security. Ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in conflict situations is not only the right thing to do, from a humanitarian perspective, but it is also an obligation under international humanitarian law, especially the Fourth Geneva Convention.

I wish to share two important data trends before I offer three observations.

The first data trend is that the world is moving towards greater food insecurity. According to the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023*, nearly 258 million people are in crisis or worse — acute food insecurity. And according to preliminary assessments by the Secretary-General on progress on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), the number of people facing hunger is likely to reach 650 million people in 2030. This trend is one of the reasons why the General Assembly, in resolution 76/264, adopted last year, called on the international community to urgently support countries affected by a food security crisis.

The second trend is just as significant — conflict is a significant driver of such food insecurity in many affected countries, and in some countries, it is the main driver.

The report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians in armed conflict (S/2023/345), issued earlier this month, states that conflict and insecurity were the most significant drivers of food insecurity for some 117 million people in 19 countries. That amplifies the link between armed conflict and violence and conflict-induced food insecurity and the threat of famine and the need to take steps to protect civilians. That has been well underscored by the Security Council for some time now, since in its resolution 2417 (2018).

In view of those trends, I wish to make the following three quick observations.

First, all concerned parties should respect and fulfil their obligations — humanitarian and legal — to protect civilians in conflict situations and to ensure their food supply. As the Secretary-General said earlier this morning, “law overlooked is law undermined.” International humanitarian law should not be overlooked, but rather continue to be promoted. We commend the role of the International Committee of the Red Cross in that regard. Civilians in conflict situations, and indeed in all situations, should not have to experience hunger and starvation. Steps should be taken to limit the impact of conflict on livelihoods, agricultural production and related infrastructure because those will have consequences in the longer term for human security, economic recovery and for an enduring peace in the post-conflict period.

Secondly, no longer is the impact of conflict, including on food security for civilians, confined primarily to the areas of conflict or its neighbourhood. Due to the current global supply chain and our interconnected world, the consequences are global. For example, 17 per cent of global food and feed products were affected by export restrictions in many countries as a result of conflict, according to the 2023 *Global Report*. And the resulting food price inflation and cost of living increases have had the most significant impacts on vulnerable countries, especially low-income countries.

Thirdly, it is therefore important that the twin processes of enhancing peaceful means and promoting sustainable development, including food security, continue to be a priority in intergovernmental processes here at the United Nations — from enhancing the Organization’s convening power for peaceful resolution of disputes, to strengthening its peaceful-

means instruments, to developing strategic foresight for the United Nations to scan beyond the time horizon for potential problems impacting global peace and stability. Those should all be key components of the New Agenda for Peace.

At the same time, an accelerated programme with a reinvigorated commitment to attaining the SDGs, with a strong emphasis on promoting food security, should continue to be supported at the upcoming SDG Summit and beyond — from reinforcing safe, global and regional food supply chains and, especially, distribution channels for humanitarian supplies to conflict areas, to developing an economic landscape and trade rules conducive to such supply chains and to promoting sustainable agriculture and food production, with the help of innovation and technology. Those are elements of people-centred sustainable development, anchored in food security for all, which should be pursued.

In conclusion, it is our hope that civilians, whether or not in conflict situations, will continue to experience food security, achieve human security and be shielded — to the greatest extent possible — from the devastating impacts of conflict.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Uruguay.

Mrs. González (Uruguay) (*spoke in Spanish*): At the outset, I would like to thank the Permanent Mission of Switzerland for convening this open debate and for allowing the States Members of the United Nations that are not Council members to voice their thoughts on a particularly important topic, the protection of civilians, linking it to two fundamental and applicable aspects — food security and basic services.

My delegation associates itself with the statements made on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect and the Group of Friends of the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict.

Many food crises in recent decades have laid bare the shortcomings of the international community with regard to managing food security in conflict situations. National Governments with conflicting parties are often unable or unwilling to respond adequately to food crises. Humanitarian aid operations face challenges when providing aid and avoiding the exacerbation of the conflict. Food insecurity does not result from war, but rather is central to the dynamics underpinning violent conflict, as vulnerable people are the most affected.

The number of people living in food insecurity is increasing worldwide. Many current food crises result from armed conflicts. The most obvious impact of violent conflicts and/or protracted food security crises is the destruction of farmlands, irrigation systems and infrastructure. We are also seeing massive population displacement and widespread famine due to violent conflicts, which have negative and, often, lasting consequences for the food security of the affected populations.

Chronic food insecurity can be a decisive factor in the prolongation and exacerbation of violent conflict, thus creating a vicious cycle of violence and hunger. These situations have an impact on climate change, which triggers economic and health crises, long after those conflicts are resolved. The destruction wrought by war and the degradation of farmlands and related infrastructure, as well as the expansion of zones of war, trigger large-scale displacement, as we see currently in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Yemen, Afghanistan, Syria, the Sudan, Nigeria, Ethiopia, South Sudan and Ukraine. I do not want to be remiss and not mention, in our region, Haiti, which the representative of our region on the Security Council, Ecuador, specifically referred to this morning. The use of arms and conventional munitions, as well as chemical weapons, which have a harmful impact both on the environment and health, must be mentioned as well. Food insecurity can also become a weapon when violent conflicts target specific sectors of the population or ethnic, religious or political groups or when the access of humanitarian organizations, which provide assistance or essential services to affected populations, is impeded.

In the face of that reality, it is an imperative to promote the systematic implementation of existing instruments and frameworks to address food insecurity brought about by conflicts and to protect essential services. We also need to ensure better cooperation among the Security Council, parties to the conflict and the rest of our membership.

We underscore the importance of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, an agreement reached under the aegis of the United Nations, which was signed by Russia, Ukraine and Türkiye on 22 July 2022 and recently extended on 18 May, to facilitate the export of grain and related foods and fertilizers from Ukrainian ports. However, it can be further honed, especially after hearing the comments made at a high-level meeting last

week. It is also vital, in that connection, to exchange information and to foster partnerships that would allow a comprehensive and coordinated approach.

As was stated by the representative of the International Committee of the Red Cross this morning, we should foster diplomatic negotiations and mediation to prevent conflicts. We should also promote peacebuilding initiatives to tackle the root causes of conflicts and to create an environment conducive to ensuring food security and basic services.

At the legal level, all parties to conflict must strengthen their commitment to guaranteeing access to food as a human right. Resolution 2417 (2018) grants a new framework for United Nations agencies and States and must be used effectively to determine if assistance is being provided to civilians in conflicts.

We should also point to the fact that the inequality of food systems disproportionately affects women and girls, which makes them more vulnerable to food insecurity and malnutrition. That is exacerbated by climate change and the aforementioned factors. It is not because of the disproportionately negative impact that they have in this situation that we must address those issues from a gender perspective, but rather because the achievement of gender equality and the empowerment of all women and girls can increase food security, improve nutrition and make food systems more resilient and sustainable for all, both in times of peace and armed conflict.

Food assistance is vital to reduce the effects of conflicts in the short and long term and is an important issue of international humanitarian law. Improving cooperation between United Nations agencies and non-governmental organizations and gaining a better understanding of local mechanisms for responding to food crises and conflicts and the local perspectives with regard to peace must be borne in mind when it comes to planning and implementing aid operations and national response strategies. Humanitarian corridors, including the cooperation of humanitarian organizations such as the Red Cross and Red Crescent societies, must be secured.

In that regard, there needs to be better awareness of the impacts of conflicts on food security and essential services, and perhaps there needs to be less politicization, thereby strengthening political will and the effective implementation of resolution 2417 (2018), resolution 2573 (2021) and resolution 2664 (2022) pertaining to

humanitarian exemptions on assets freezes established pursuant to United Nations sanctions regimes, which are important in facilitating humanitarian assistance. States must fully implement all those resolutions and incorporate them in their national policies and programmes and support humanitarian initiatives and initiatives linked to sustainable development, in cooperation with international organizations, including regional organizations and humanitarian agencies.

The role of the United Nations system, its partners in implementation and non-governmental organizations is vital when it comes to ensuring a global response to the insecurity crisis, in particular armed conflict. The Security Council is at the centre of that effort and must protect those principles and rights and ensure the commitment of the membership of the Organization in that regard.

In conclusion, Uruguay urges the States involved in armed conflicts once again to respect human rights, international law and humanitarian law in general in conflicts and in particular to respect the need to guarantee access to humanitarian assistance. We call for the cessation of activities that limit and jeopardize humanitarian operations, which are seeking to meet peoples' basic needs.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Romania.

Mr. Feruță (Romania): At the outset, I would like to express our gratitude to the Swiss presidency for choosing this important topic and for giving, throughout the whole month of May, such importance to these topical issues.

Romania is a staunch supporter of multilateralism and the three United Nations pillars — peace and security, human rights and development. My country is confronted with such realities at its external border with Ukraine, where civilians are killed, wounded or starved.

In addition to the points made by the delegation of the European Union, I want to add a few points.

To ensure the rights of civilians in conflict means to allow unimpeded access to humanitarian players to the areas where civilians need such aid. Given the unfolding wars and crises taking place before our eyes, unimpeded access should be available for the humanitarian actors that operate in the Sudan, Ukraine, Yemen or Afghanistan for the benefit of the populations. We need

to improve humanitarians' capacities to stay on the ground and deliver aid in accordance with the provisions of international humanitarian law. Indeed, international humanitarian law prohibits weaponizing access to food and starvation as a method of war. We welcome the continuation of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, but greater predictability in access to food globally is necessary.

Unimpeded access to food is part of the wide array of instruments of international humanitarian law, as it ensures human dignity and human security.

In the past year, Romania alone has facilitated the transit of over 16 million tons of grain from Ukraine, which is half of the grain transited via the Black Sea Grain Initiative. The more routes remain open for the grain to become available to those in need, the more we move away from the brink of a food crisis or malnutrition. It is in that context that we find appalling the findings of the recent reports of UNICEF on the skyrocketing levels of acute malnutrition among 2.3 million girls and boys in Afghanistan.

The protection of civilians in conflicts is intimately related to climate and security, a reality that is sadly witnessed by children, the elderly, women and girls, and men and boys. The earthquakes in Syria and Türkiye and Cyclones Freddy, which affected Malawi and Mozambique in March, and Mocha, which hit Bangladesh and Myanmar last week, are clear examples of how extreme weather events further exacerbate the plight of civilians.

The protection of civilians also means curtailing the culture of impunity and enhancing accountability. We welcome the specific recommendation in the report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians in armed conflict to:

“Investigate alleged war crimes, crimes against humanity and crimes of genocide, prosecute perpetrators, ensure reparations for victims and guarantees of non-repetition, strengthen States' capacity and resources to investigate and prosecute” (S/2023/345, para. 90 (j)).

My delegation also echoes the appeal of the Secretary-General in the same report for countries to become a party to the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court (ICC) and cooperate fully with the ICC and other investigative and judicial mechanisms. We all need to take such measures to ensure the security and dignity of civilians in conflict.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Luxembourg.

Mr. Maes (Luxembourg) (*spoke in French*): Luxembourg would like to thank Switzerland for having organized this open debate on the protection of civilians during its presidency of the Security Council.

My country fully aligns itself with the statement of the European Union and the statements of the Group of Friends on the Protection of Civilians and the Group of Friends on the Responsibility to Protect. I would like to add a few comments in my national capacity.

We thank the Secretary-General for his report (S/2023/345) and recommendations. His conclusion is clear: we must strengthen the protection of civilians. We also thank the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross for her statement and her appeal to make respect for international humanitarian law a political priority. We are also grateful to Ms. Aïchatou Mounkaïla for highlighting the role women play in combating food insecurity and protecting essential services.

Providing sustainable access to quality basic services is a priority of Luxembourg's development cooperation and humanitarian action. To enable humanitarian actors to operate in increasingly difficult contexts, innovation is required. That is why Luxembourg, in partnership with the World Food Programme, launched a humanitarian innovation accelerator this year, which supports the development of new solutions for access to services.

In its resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), the Security Council strongly condemned the use of starvation as a method of warfare, which can constitute a war crime. Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine has highlighted the links between conflict, hunger and critical civilian infrastructure. It has exacerbated food insecurity in Ukraine and around the world. In this context, we welcome efforts to ensure the continuity of the Black Sea Grain Initiative.

Attacks on civilian infrastructure, including schools and hospitals, can constitute war crimes and crimes against humanity. These crimes must be prosecuted. We welcome the investigations by the Ukrainian judicial authorities and the International Criminal Court into Russia's massive attacks on civilian infrastructure in Ukraine. In general, Luxembourg remains firmly

committed to the Safe Schools Declaration, and we encourage all Member States that have not yet done so to sign it.

I would like to conclude by reaffirming Luxembourg's full support for the crucial mandate of the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) in promoting international humanitarian law and protecting civilians in conflict. We are proud to have been able to strengthen our strategic partnership with the ICRC with the opening in Luxembourg this year of the Delegation for Cyberspace. The Council can continue to count on our support.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Slovenia.

Mr. Malovrh (Slovenia): Let me join speakers before me in thanking the Secretary-General and the briefers from the International Committee of the Red Cross and civil society for their valuable and sobering briefings earlier today. Slovenia aligns itself with the statement made by the representative of the European Union, in its capacity as observer, and I wish to make some additional remarks in my national capacity.

The situation of civilians in armed conflicts around the world remains alarming. The latest report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) paints a very dark picture of a 53 per cent increase in civilian deaths in 2022, with more than 100 million persons worldwide being forcibly displaced and a quarter of a billion people facing acute hunger. Women, children, older persons and persons with disabilities are the most adversely affected.

In that regard, I would like to highlight three points.

First, on respect for international humanitarian law, the unprecedented disrespect for civilian lives and disregard for the norms and laws aimed at protecting civilians is alarming. We call on all parties to armed conflict to respect their obligations under international humanitarian law. Resolution 2417 (2018) is clear. It calls for compliance with the obligations set forth under international humanitarian law, including ensuring safe and unimpeded access of humanitarian personnel to civilians. It calls for the protection of civilian infrastructure critical for delivering humanitarian aid and for the proper functioning of food and water systems, and it acknowledges the link between conflict

and hunger and the need to break the vicious cycle and establish accountability for those who exploit starvation as a method of warfare.

Recognizing this challenge, earlier this year, Slovenia hosted an international conference on legal challenges and the protection of critical infrastructure and environments during armed conflicts and respect for international humanitarian law. The message was clear. Full respect for international law is a prerequisite for maintaining peace and security and stability.

Secondly, on protecting the natural environment, as an environmentally conscious country, Slovenia pays special attention to promoting the environment in armed conflicts. Negative impacts from the destruction of critical infrastructure, soil contamination, water pollution and disrupted sanitation systems cause severe and lasting consequences that will be felt for generations to come. We believe water resources and installations should be of particular consideration in conflict prevention, conflict resolution and peacebuilding efforts. Contamination by unexploded ordnance and landmines also severely challenges food production. With our partner, the Slovenian organization ITF Enhancing Human Security, we will continue to address the scourge of antipersonnel mines in mine-affected regions in 30 countries worldwide.

Thirdly, on early action and addressing root causes, while conflicts are among the main drivers of food insecurity and hunger, they can no longer be viewed as isolated drivers. Economic, political and environmental factors deepen food insecurity and its long-term effects. Addressing all root causes of food insecurity is paramount. We believe that the peace and security effects of climate change should both be discussed in this Chamber. All peacekeeping and peacebuilding interventions must be climate-sensitive and climate-resilient. Peacekeeping and political missions should heighten their attention to climate-related risk in their areas of operation.

Slovenia supports strengthening the nexus between humanitarian development, peace assistance and placing food security at the centre of this work. Slovenia has increased its financial support for food security sixfold last year, and we have earmarked a share of these funds for preventive action and resilience-building in countries facing food insecurity. We also welcome the extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which is important for global food security, especially for the most vulnerable countries.

The year 2022 has been among the most food-insecure years on record, with devastating effects on civilians. Armed conflicts, the economic downturn, the recovery from pandemic and the impacts of climate change have created the perfect storm of crises. Preventing civilian suffering is not optional; it is our collective responsibility, regardless of whether a situation is on the Security Council's agenda or not.

We also understand today's debate to be a sequel to the Arria Formula meeting on the protection of water, which Switzerland organized together with Mozambique. We understand food security and water security as two sides of the same coin — two key aspects of the protection-of-civilians discussion — and appreciate the systematic approach of the two presidencies.

Finally, as a candidate country for the Security Council, Slovenia will continue to promote the agenda and positively contribute to the protection of civilians in conflict situations.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Chile.

Mrs. Narváez Ojeda (Chile) (*spoke in Spanish*): We welcome the opportunity to participate in today's open debate. We take note of the briefings and statements heard today.

There is no doubt that the protection of civilians is a central part of peace operations. Observance and compliance in this area is a humanitarian imperative; this has become an elementary rule of peacekeeping and therefore of the United Nations system. Promoting the rule of law and accountability and full compliance with human rights, international law and international humanitarian law is fundamental to the protection of civilians.

Based on the foregoing, States Members of the United Nations must implement provisions for the protection of civilians in their national legislation and ensure that they are implemented in armed conflict. Indeed, we recognize the occasions on which the Security Council and/or the General Assembly have established follow-up mechanisms when belligerent forces have violated the protection of civilians. We firmly believe that the international register of damage allows for comprehensive monitoring of conflicts. Similarly, more countries need to consent to the jurisdiction of the International Criminal Court, a specialized court that can prosecute such war crimes as attacks on civilian infrastructure, essential services and the suppression of food supplies.

We recognize the contributions made by resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), which focus on mitigating the effects of conflict on food insecurity. It is imperative that the Security Council addresses emerging risks in conflict that affect both food security and the protection of essential services.

We believe that consideration could be given to the gender perspective and how food insecurity or the absence of relevant services may have a differential impact on women.

The first of those emerging risks is climate change, the impact of which, in combination with socioeconomic and/or political factors, exacerbates the risk of violence caused by food insecurity, as well as by economic crises and migration. Climate change can lead to droughts, floods and other natural disasters that affect food production.

Similarly, armed conflicts are causing unprecedented forced displacements of people and refugees, which can disrupt food production and further increase food insecurity.

A third element to consider is armed and criminal groups using control over food production and distribution as part of their war strategies. The Security Council, together with other specialized agencies, can work to disrupt those war economies and ensure that food reaches those who need it most.

Finally, we wish to stress the importance of preventing conflict itself. We therefore call for united work by the Security Council, together with regional organizations, the Peacebuilding Commission and, above all, civil society, including women on a permanent basis, to achieve long-term solutions to food insecurity caused by conflict.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Greece.

Mr. Sekeris (Greece): Greece aligns itself with the statement delivered earlier by the observer of the European Union and would like to add the following in its national capacity.

We would like to thank Switzerland for organizing this timely open debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict.

Conflicts remain the major causes of hunger, affecting global markets and supply chains, with the ongoing war in Ukraine further exacerbating the so-

called triple-F crisis of food, fuel and fertilizers. That crisis is even further aggravated when conflict is combined with other factors, such as climate change.

In that context, the implementation of resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021) remains critical. Full compliance with international humanitarian law remains of utmost importance, and all parties to armed conflicts should abide by humanitarian principles. The contribution of the International Committee of the Red Cross in that regard is of utmost importance. Attention should also be paid to demining operations, so that arable lands are safe for agricultural activities.

No effort should be spared to ensure humanitarian access to those in need. We need to safeguard civilian infrastructure from any attacks, while the safety of humanitarian personnel should remain our top priority. An emphasis should be placed on the protection of the most vulnerable, such as women and children. Of particular concern is the safety of female humanitarian workers, whose role is indispensable in providing essential services to women and girls.

Digital technologies and artificial intelligence can play a constructive role, including through the dissemination of critical information. However, we should remain vigilant so that this tool will not be used to the detriment of civilians by spreading misinformation or even through cyberattacks, which can threaten vital civilian infrastructure.

Moreover, we need to act pre-emptively, strengthening the links between early warning and early action in conflict-driven food crises. In that vein, every Government should pursue preventive policies and adopt emergency actions to secure food for its population. If a Government lacks the capacity to prevent or mitigate a food crisis, it should facilitate relief operations in accordance with international humanitarian law. Improving food security requires coordination and complementarity among actors in humanitarian assistance. In that respect, the work of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs is commendable.

I would like to stress that Greece is particularly committed to delivering humanitarian assistance to regions severely affected by conflict-induced hunger, such as sub-Saharan Africa, the Sahel and the Horn of Africa. In that regard, we are contributing financially to the reconstruction of the port of Benghazi in Libya — a hub that facilitates the provision of foodstuffs to the broader region.

In addition to the above, in the framework of the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which has played a vital role in reducing global food and fertilizer prices, fleets of Greek interests involved in maritime transportation worldwide carry 50 per cent of the total volume of products currently exported by Ukraine.

Finally, we are engaged in all relevant discussions at the United Nations, including on the New Agenda for Peace. Preventing conflict is the most effective means of preventing famine. While humanitarian assistance is essential, the solution is peace. As a Security Council candidate for the period 2025–2026, Greece remains committed to the promotion of international peace and security and to the peaceful resolution of conflicts.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Argentina.

Mr. Mainero (Argentina) (*spoke in Spanish*): At the outset, allow me to congratulate Switzerland on its presidency of the Security Council and on convening this important open debate.

The Security Council must remain committed to the protection of civilians in armed conflict and to the promotion of full respect for international law, in particular international humanitarian law and international human rights law, as well as to the fight against impunity.

Argentina would like to stress, once again, the value and significance of the 1949 Geneva Conventions, which represented a remarkable step forward for the international community in the normative evolution of international humanitarian law. Seven decades later, conflicts continue to exist, and it is regrettable that there are still many situations in which civilians are the target of attacks, with unacceptable deaths among the civilian population; in which children are recruited as soldiers and abused; in which thousands and even millions of people are displaced; and in which humanitarian access is impossible or seriously curtailed. Many of those situations are exacerbated by impunity.

We thank the Secretary-General for his report (S/2023/345) and appreciate its recommendations and conclusions. The Secretary-General's report highlights that, in 2022, more than 250 million people suffered from acute hunger in 58 countries and territories, many of them in armed conflict. It also states that conflict and insecurity were the most significant factors driving

the high levels of food insecurity, which affected an estimated 117 million people in 19 countries and territories.

Armed conflict generates food insecurity by destroying farms, roads and ports, by paralysing the economy and by disrupting humanitarian access. Food insecurity, in turn, can become a trigger for violence, instability and migration and can be a factor in recruitment by terrorist groups.

In recent years, the Security Council has focused its attention on the link between conflict and hunger. In 2017, when the Secretary-General warned the Council of the threat of famine in various regions, the Council, in a presidential statement, deplored the failure of the parties to those conflicts to ensure sustained and unfettered access to deliveries of life-saving food assistance (S/PRST/2017/14).

In May 2018, the Council adopted resolution 2417 (2018), recalling the link between armed conflict and conflict-induced food insecurity. The resolution strongly condemned the use of civilian starvation as a method of warfare, as well as the unlawful denial of humanitarian access, and urged all parties to conflict to protect critical civilian infrastructure to ensure the proper functioning of food systems.

The Secretary-General's report highlights that, five years after the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018), armed conflict remains the main driver of hunger. International humanitarian law prohibits the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare and provides protection for the assets needed to produce food and clean water. Despite those provisions of international humanitarian law, hunger is alarmingly often a consequence of armed conflict, either because belligerents deliberately cause it, thus violating their obligations, or because it arises as an indirect result of the destruction caused by war. What is clear is that respect for the rules of international humanitarian law can help to mitigate the impacts of armed conflict on food security.

An important element in the protection of civilians is the investigation of the facts and accountability for those responsible for crimes against civilians. In that regard, Argentina considers it appropriate to point out that international humanitarian law offers a tool to investigate events that could constitute grave breaches of the Geneva Conventions by an impartial entity, namely, the International Humanitarian Fact-Finding Commission provided for in the first Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions.

Argentina would also like to highlight the fundamental role of the International Criminal Court (ICC) in the fight against impunity. The ICC is a key tool in the quest for justice, and it is often the Security Council that holds the key to access to the Court. In conflict zones, both State and non-State actors continue to perpetrate attacks on civilians, and victims' registries can shed light on conduct during hostilities and help identify the parties responsible. Argentina encourages all parties to conflicts to record and track casualties in a consistent manner in collaboration with the relevant internationally mandated bodies. The registration of victims is a fundamental tool for early warning of potential mass-scale atrocity crimes and for understanding other threats to civilians.

More than 20 years after the adoption of resolution 1265 (1999), the first Security Council resolution on the protection of civilians in armed conflict, civilians continue to represent the vast majority of conflict victims. The problem lies not in the current normative framework but in the translation and implementation of the norms in practice. In order to translate the normative advances of the past 20 years into demonstrable results, the Security Council, and the international community as a whole, must advocate for a more robust implementation of the existing normative framework.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Portugal.

Ms. Zacarias (Portugal): I would like to thank Switzerland for convening this debate and the briefers for their insights this morning.

Portugal aligns itself with the statement made by the Director-General for General European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations of the European Commission on behalf of the European Union, and the statements made by the representatives of Kuwait and Croatia on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, respectively. I would like to underline three points in my national capacity.

First, we welcome the Secretary-General's annual report (S/2023/345) on the protection of civilians. We are encouraged by some positive steps, such as the adoption of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas, the recent renewal of

the Black Sea Grain Initiative and Mozambique's establishment of the Interministerial Commission on Human Rights and International Humanitarian Law, as President Nyusi mentioned this morning. However, the overall situation remains very concerning. Civilian deaths increased by 53 per cent in 2022, and half of them were the result of Russia's war of aggression in Ukraine. And two thirds of people experiencing acute hunger live in conflict-affected areas. States bear responsibility.

Secondly, in that regard, States must protect, respect and fulfil the human right to food, safe drinking water and sanitation recognized under international human rights law. To that end, we must ensure compliance with international humanitarian law, while strengthening efforts to disseminate and implement resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021) in order to ensure coordination between the Security Council and the Human Rights Council and its special procedure, as well as synergies with other relevant actors. And we also need to align efforts in the areas of peace, development and humanitarian action, in order to ensure complementarity and address root causes while also bearing in mind the impacts of climate change.

Lastly, we have to combine short-term action with long-term solutions to be effective. We need strategic foresight and accountability. We need more systemic coordination of emergency relief and humanitarian-worker protection. Sanctions regimes must provide for humanitarian exemptions, in line with resolution 2664 (2022). The right of civilians to education and health during armed conflicts must be respected. We need strategies that emphasize sustainable development and respect for human rights, while mobilizing technology to ensure that food and water systems are resilient and ecologically balanced. Moreover, we need to be inclusive. Civilians are not faceless masses. They are communities torn apart by conflict. We need to listen and work with them at the local level. In short, we must support vulnerable countries while respecting their national priorities and ownership, scale up humanitarian operations and safeguard livelihoods as we promote political dialogue. That is the way to go if we are to break the vicious cycle of armed conflicts and food insecurity.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Belgium.

Ms. Marchand (Belgium) (*spoke in French*): At the outset, let me warmly congratulate you, Madam President, on the historical significance that your presidency of the Security Council represents. I would also like to thank the Secretary-General, the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross and Ms. Mounkaïla for their briefings.

My country aligns itself with the statement made by the Director-General for General European Civil Protection and Humanitarian Aid Operations of the European Commission on behalf of the European Union, and the statements by the representatives of Kuwait and Croatia on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect, respectively.

Civilians continue to pay a heavy price in armed conflicts. At a time when the international community is facing the largest number of conflicts we have seen since the Second World War, 2 billion people, that is, a quarter of the world's population, live in areas affected by violence. And the number of displaced persons has reached record heights. Armed conflicts result in the loss of human life, displacement and sexual violence. They lead to the exploitation of natural resources, the destruction of critical infrastructure, the interruption of essential services for civilians and serious shortages of food and water, with a disproportionate impact on women, girls and other vulnerable people. Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine has further compounded that pattern, leading to massive displacement and heightened food insecurity for millions of people all over the world. Those challenges call for a strong response by the international community. In that regard, we welcome the renewal of the Black Sea Grain Initiative. As the Secretary-General underlines in his report on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345), armed conflicts remain the main cause of food insecurity. We must break the cycle of conflict and hunger, support the economies of vulnerable countries and come up with comprehensive solutions to combat the multiple drivers of food insecurity in conflicts. We welcome the recommendations set forth by the Secretary-General in his report and call on all relevant stakeholders to implement them.

(*spoke in English*)

With regard to today's debate, my country would like to stress four points. First, strict compliance with international humanitarian law by all parties to armed

conflicts remains critical for the protection of civilians and the resources and objects indispensable to their survival. We welcomed the adoption last year of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas, under which States agreed to adopt and implement policies and practices to avoid harming civilians, including by restricting or refraining from the use of explosive weapons in populated areas. We call on all States to adhere to the Declaration.

Secondly, the Council must step up its efforts to end the scourge of armed conflict and use the full range of tools at its disposal to respond to the humanitarian and food crises fuelled by conflict. It is imperative to advance the implementation of the relevant Security Council resolutions, such as resolution 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), which reaffirm the prohibition on the use of starvation of civilians, including children, as a method of warfare.

Thirdly, States should strengthen accountability mechanisms at both the domestic and international levels. They should conduct investigations into violations of international humanitarian law related to the use of starvation as a method of warfare, including the unlawful denial of humanitarian assistance. When national jurisdictions fail to take action, the Council has the tools to activate a range of international investigation and accountability mechanisms. In that regard, we welcome the amendment to the Rome Statute that includes as a war crime the intentional starving of civilians as a method of warfare in non-international armed conflict, and we call on Member States to adhere to the Statute and to ratify that amendment.

Lastly, the Council should make better use of the early-warning and prevention functions of resolution 2417 (2018) and request regular briefings on contexts where conflict is a leading driver of hunger. The Secretary-General also has an important role to play in alerting the Council when there is a risk of conflict-induced famine and widespread food insecurity in the context of an armed conflict. In that regard, we also welcomed as a positive measure the appointment last year of the United Nations Famine Prevention and Response Coordinator.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Cambodia.

Mrs. Eat (Cambodia): I would first like to express my appreciation to Switzerland for convening today's debate on ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in conflicts. The updates given by the Secretary-General and the views of the briefers and speakers have been insightful and relevant.

It is sad to see that the number of people facing acute food insecurity increased from 193 million in 2021 to 258 million in 2022, largely as a result of armed conflicts. That increase, despite the Security Council's adoption of relevant resolutions, reflects severe shortcomings in our efforts to address peace and security issues. I would like to make three points.

First, all of the parties to any conflict should be urged to take equal responsibility in facilitating safe access for humanitarian organizations to reach civilians in need, with full impartiality assured. That could be in the form of safe camps in conflict zones with secure corridors to them for civilians' passage and the delivery of aid.

Secondly, Member States should prioritize the prevention of the further escalation of existing conflicts by urging the parties concerned to find common ground with regard to the root causes of their conflicts so that they can be effectively addressed. It is easier said than done, but we should persist nonetheless.

Thirdly, we urge for every effort to be made to prevent the harming of civilian infrastructure and essential services, food production and supply chains, in line with international humanitarian law. There is no lack of established laws and norms, but there is a lack of commitment to honouring them.

My delegation hopes that the Security Council can play a leading role involving all the relevant United Nations institutions and stakeholders, including the Peacebuilding Commission, in order to realize the aspirations outlined in those three points and save the Sustainable Development Goals from the negative impact of violent conflicts around the world.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Kingdom of the Netherlands.

Ms. Brandt (Kingdom of the Netherlands): I thank you, Madam President, as well as your country, Switzerland, for organizing this crucially important open debate on the occasion of the anniversary of the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018).

We align ourselves with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union, as well as the statements delivered by the representatives of Ireland, on behalf of the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger, and Kuwait, on behalf of the Group of Friends on the Protection of Civilians in Armed Conflict.

We would also like to add a few points in our national capacity, because the Kingdom of the Netherlands is proud to have been a co-penholder for resolution 2417 (2018) and to have played a part in its adoption when we were on the Security Council. Unfortunately, five years on, the situation is worse than it was in 2018. As others have pointed out, humanitarian needs are at unprecedented levels and conflict is still the single most important driver of those record-breaking needs, including in countries that are now facing famine. The direct and indirect impact of armed conflict on hunger is obvious, as the representative of Argentina just eloquently outlined. All of that means that resolution 2417 (2018) is even more important today than it was five years ago. I would like to highlight three points in that regard.

First, the link between conflict and hunger is a matter of international security that concerns us all. It is not just an issue for humanitarian organizations. We must all work to break the vicious cycle between conflict and hunger.

Secondly, resolution 2417 (2018) recalls that the use of the starvation of civilians is prohibited under international humanitarian law, including in non-international armed conflict, reminding us that like gender-based violence, it should never be accepted, including in times of war. We are collectively responsible for upholding those norms, not just in words but in practice, and for ensuring accountability when they are not respected.

Thirdly, resolution 2417 (2018) helps in anticipating and rapidly addressing situations of acute food insecurity that result from armed conflict. In fact, it commits the members of the Security Council to paying full attention to the reports of the Secretary-General on that issue.

Resolution 2417 (2018) was a landmark resolution, yet it is clear that we should do more to strengthen its implementation. In that regard, I have two suggestions. First, the resolution calls on the Secretary-General to report to the Security Council when conflict leads to severe food insecurity. While we welcome the efforts

made so far in that regard, in particular those outlined in this year's report of the Secretary-General on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345), we feel that more frequent reporting under the resolution is necessary.

Secondly, and most importantly, such reporting should lead to swift action by the Council, in line with resolution 2417 (2018). The Security Council should take those reports seriously and take concrete action when hunger is used as a weapon. Only then will the resolution do what it is intended to do — make a difference in people's lives, as it did in 2018, when action by the Council contributed to averting a famine in Yemen.

In conclusion, the resolution's full potential needs to be brought to bear in these times of increasing humanitarian needs. We need to act — and act together — to break the vicious cycle between conflict and hunger. And we hope that this week, focused on the protection of civilians, and today's open debate will strengthen our commitment and provide the inspiration we need to achieve those collective goals. I can assure the Council of the continued support of the Kingdom of the Netherlands in that regard. And let me repeat what my Cambodian colleague just said. It is easier said than done, but let us be persistent.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Estonia.

Mr. Tammsaar (Estonia): I would like to thank you, Madam President, for convening today's open debate of the Security Council.

Estonia aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union.

Estonia remains gravely concerned about the situation of civilians in the cases addressed in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345), including in Afghanistan, Somalia, the Sudan, Syria and Ukraine. We underline the need to ensure humanitarian access and the ability of humanitarian workers, including women, to conduct their activities safely and without constraints. In order to put an end to attacks on civilians and deter those who wish to challenge peace, there must be full accountability in place. In cases that have already been referred to the International Criminal Court (ICC), further backing from the Security Council or the General Assembly is of paramount importance.

According to a rather conservative estimate in the Secretary-General's report, almost half of the

reported civilian casualties in the world in 2022 were a direct result of Russia's aggression against Ukraine. In Ukraine, Russia has killed, tortured, raped and deliberately bombed civilians, as well as targeting civilian infrastructure and forcibly displacing civilians, including children. The latter issue is why Putin and Lvova-Belova are on the ICC's most-wanted list. Those heinous crimes are also the reason why Russia should be listed in the annexes to the Secretary-General's upcoming annual report on children and armed conflict as a party committing grave violations against children.

The aggression against Ukraine has also reduced Ukraine's grain exports by at least a third. We welcome the extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative. However, Ukraine and the world need Russia to end its war. Only then will farmers be able to return to their fields and normal worldwide agricultural trade be restored, which would improve global food security significantly. Russia is blocking humanitarian aid access to the temporarily occupied territories of Ukraine and has caused enormous numbers of deaths among health-care workers, thereby deliberately ignoring resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021). Of the 25 journalists killed in conflict, as recorded by UNESCO, 10 were killed in Ukraine. In that regard, regrettably, the implementation of resolution 2222 (2015), on the protection of journalists, has still not been achieved.

In conclusion, every Member State has a part to play in supporting and protecting civilians affected by armed conflict. Since February 2022, Estonia has opened its borders to more than 70,000 Ukrainian refugees, which is equivalent to more than 5 per cent of our population. We are also issuing 35 residency permits per year to journalists in need in order to protect free journalism and support independent media around the world. We will continue our support to improving global food security, including through the World Food Programme.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Lithuania.

Mr. Paulauskas (Lithuania): I sincerely thank the Swiss presidency of the Security Council for organizing today's important debate.

Lithuania aligns itself with the statement made earlier on behalf of the European Union.

It has been more than 20 years since resolution 1265 (1999) was unanimously adopted. That resolution was a significant step in addressing the protection of civilians

during armed conflict. Since then, the Security Council has adopted numerous resolutions emphasizing the need to protect civilians and abide by international humanitarian law. However, we are still witnessing active conflicts worldwide, in which civilians suffer the most, leading to millions being displaced from their homes. According to the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/345), there were at least 16,988 civilian deaths in 2022 across 12 armed conflicts. Shockingly, almost half of those deaths were caused by Russia's aggression against Ukraine, which resulted in 7,957 casualties. The actual numbers may be much higher. Russia's continual attacks on civilians in Ukraine, along with the deliberate destruction of 700 critical infrastructure facilities and cyberoperations targeting electricity, the Internet and transportation services, represent serious violations of international humanitarian law.

Children are particularly affected by armed conflict. According to a report from UNICEF, the education of approximately 5.7 million children in Ukraine has been disrupted, and 1.5 million children are facing mental health issues. We also want to highlight Russia's large-scale attempts to abduct and transfer children from Ukraine to Russia. We fully support the investigation of the International Criminal Court and its decision to issue arrest warrants against Russia's President, Vladimir Putin, and his current Children's Rights Commissioner, Maria Lvova-Belova, for possible war crimes involving the unlawful deportation and transfer of children from the occupied areas of Ukraine. We also underline the importance of resisting all attempts by Russia to instrumentalize the United Nations system in covering up and shifting the blame for those serious crimes.

Another crucial document, resolution 2417 (2018), adopted in 2018, strongly condemned the deliberate use of starvation as a tactic of warfare and the obstruction of humanitarian aid aimed at alleviating hunger among civilian populations affected by conflicts. We fully support the Secretary-General's efforts to break the cycle connecting armed conflicts with food insecurity and seek political solutions that strengthen the economies of vulnerable nations. Extending the Black Sea Grain Initiative is a positive development, and we are grateful to the United Nations, Türkiye and others involved for their dedicated work. However, it will also be crucial for Russia to stop using food as a weapon and demonstrate a genuine commitment to full compliance with the agreement. We urge countries,

especially developing countries, involved in fertilizer production to seize the opportunity to enhance their production capabilities and play a stronger role in the global fertilizer market. That will not only contribute to global food security but also enhance the stability of agricultural systems worldwide.

Lithuania fully supports the Secretary-General's recommendations in his report, which include calling for investigations into alleged war crimes, crimes against humanity and acts of genocide. It is crucial to hold those responsible accountable, provide reparations to victims and establish measures to prevent similar atrocities in the future. The International Criminal Court should exercise its jurisdiction whenever appropriate. We also recognize and appreciate the efforts of the United Nations, the International Committee of the Red Cross, regional organizations and non-governmental organizations in implementing international humanitarian law. Their dedication to protecting civilians, safeguarding civilian infrastructure and addressing food insecurity is commendable.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Jordan.

Mr. Hmoud (Jordan): I am pleased to be able to begin by thanking Switzerland for organizing today's important open debate. I would also like to express our appreciation to the briefers for providing their valuable insights to the Council.

The primary responsibility for the protection of civilians and civilian objects lies with the State and non-State parties to conflicts. However, the United Nations and relevant humanitarian agencies, in particular the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC), play a very important role in implementing and supporting that protection, based on their mandates.

With regard to the United Nations, the protection of civilians and civilian objects in conflict areas should be at the centre of its mechanisms and initiatives related to protecting people caught up in conflicts as well as managing and resolving those conflicts, including through the peace processes in which the United Nations is involved. It is also vital that the Security Council and other relevant parties of the United Nations, including the Secretariat, set clear guidelines to ensure that evacuations of United Nations staff and personnel in response to eruptions of hostilities are not carried out in a way that jeopardizes the protection and well-being of civilians.

At the legal level, as the international community it is in our common interests to ensure respect for the rules of international humanitarian law related to the protection of civilians and civilian objects, including those contained in the 1907 Hague Convention IV with respect to the laws and customs of war on land and the 1949 Fourth Geneva Convention and the Protocols Additional to the Geneva Conventions. States parties to the relevant international humanitarian law instruments, as well as the ICRC, have important roles to play. But it is up to the international community as a whole to work for adherence to international humanitarian law and accountability for attacks on civilians, civilian objects and the environment.

It is the duty of the parties to a conflict, including armed groups, to respect the rules of international humanitarian law that apply to the protection of civilians and civilian objects, as well as the environment, and to prevent violations by their forces and personnel. Those rules — including the prohibition on methods and means of warfare that may cause widespread long-term and severe damage to the environment; the prohibition on attacks against civilians, civilian objects and the environment, to the extent that it remains a civilian object, and the applicability of the principles of distinction, proportionality and precaution — must be applied at all times during military operations. The rules also include a prohibition on the pillage of natural resources, the prevention by occupying Powers of significant harm to the environment of occupied territories, a prohibition on unlawful exploitation by occupying Powers of natural resources in occupied territories and a requirement that the use of such resources be sustainable and for the benefit of the protected civilian population in occupied territories.

In that regard, Jordan would like to remind members of the applicability of the Martens Clause on the protection of civilians and civilian objects, as well as the protection of the environment. That includes the prohibition on means and methods of warfare, including new technologies that are not specifically prohibited under relevant treaty rules. In that context, Jordan condemns Israel's illegal policies and actions against the protected civilian population, essential civilian infrastructure and environment in the occupied Palestinian territory, which includes the unlawful exploitation of a majority of the natural resources in the occupied Palestinian territory, including water resources. The Security Council, the primary body

responsible for the maintenance of international peace and security, has the authority and responsibility to take action in situations in which the protection of civilians and civilian objects is being undermined.

With the multiplication of armed conflicts worldwide, we continue to witness the horrors facing civilian populations as a result of conflict. We therefore must view their protection in a holistic manner that takes into account the loopholes in the existing protection regimes with a view to maximizing the efficiency of current mechanisms.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of South Africa.

Mr. Mabhongo (South Africa): We thank Switzerland for convening this important open debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict. We thank the Secretary-General and all the briefers who spoke this morning for their insightful remarks.

The Security Council is discussing this important issue at a time when the world is still engulfed with new, recurring and protracted conflict situations, with serious ramifications on civilians, especially women, children and young people. The report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) elaborates on the alarming statistics on armed conflicts and their effects on civilians, civilian safety and people's livelihoods across the world. That is true in the occupied territories of Palestine and Somalia, for example. The report projects an upward trajectory of human suffering, which is of grave concern.

More often, attacks against civilians are not only indiscriminate, but are attacks on innocent people, resulting in loss of life, lifelong injuries causing permanent damage, forced displacement, disruption of provision and lack of access to essential services, destruction of critical infrastructure, as well as livelihoods, which are already affected by the prevailing global economic pressures, such as rising food prices, energy and food insecurity. We remain concerned about the constraints to food access and the reports pertaining to the perpetual use of hunger and starvation as an instrument of war and/or access to humanitarian assistance in conflict situations. In that connection, we are concerned about the negative impact of armed conflicts — not only on food security, but also on nutrition, affecting primarily the most vulnerable.

The report of the Secretary-General also highlighted that armed conflict is the main driver of hunger. South Africa deeply regrets the rising levels of food insecurity as a result of armed conflict and the targeted attacks on critical infrastructure. We deplore the continued disregard of the Geneva Conventions and its Protocols Additional, which reiterate the need for parties in conflict to comply with their obligations and duties under international humanitarian law. It is vital that the Security Council, in keeping with that mandate, should ensure the upholding of international law and act in unison against the violations of international human rights and humanitarian law.

We recognize the important role played by the Security Council in taking decisions, where required, to strengthen the mandates of peacekeeping missions pertaining to the protection of civilians, particularly as those operations are undertaken in increasingly volatile environments. In that context, we commend the continued efforts of the United Nations peacekeeping missions, where mandated, in protecting civilians in conflict situations, while recognizing that the primary responsibility for the protection of civilians, as well as for the protection and promotion of human rights rests with the host States.

In conclusion, we applaud countries for taking steps to protect civilians and critical infrastructure, lessons for which can be drawn from, and emulated in, other conflict situations so as to maximize protection.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Bulgaria.

Mrs. Beshkova (Bulgaria): Bulgaria aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect. In my national capacity, I would like to highlight the following additional points.

At the outset, I would like to thank Switzerland for convening today's high-level open debate. I would also like to welcome the recommendations of the Secretary-General latest report (S/2023/345) and to thank the briefers for their inputs and insights this morning.

Conflicts continue to affect many parts of the world and to demonstrate how violence and instability exacerbate humanitarian challenges, including conflict-induced hunger. While, in 2022, we witnessed a reduction in civilian casualties in some contexts, like Syria and Yemen, in others, like Ukraine and Somalia,

the death toll of civilians is hitting grim records. In addition to the disturbing increase of civilian deaths in conflicts, compared with 2021, efforts by humanitarian personnel to provide assistance and to protect civilians everywhere are facing overlapping impediments, from insecurity and violence to bureaucratic hurdles.

Today, five years after the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018) and two years after the adoption of resolution 2573 (2021), the suffering of civilians is deepening and violations of basic norms are on the rise. Bulgaria therefore joins the call for compliance and respect for international humanitarian law and international human rights law by the parties to international conflicts and by all members of the international community. Parties to conflicts must ensure rapid and unhindered humanitarian access to populations in need and must facilitate the work of humanitarian actors. In that regard, it is worth recalling that the primary responsibility to protect the population in their territories rests with States.

As we need to see change in the behaviour of parties to conflicts in upholding international humanitarian law, it is equally urgent that the Council rise to its task to provide better and broader support for humanitarian action. Decisions made here or the inability to arrive at a decision could have enormous and — as we witnessed multiple times — devastating consequences around the globe. Efforts to ensure compliance and respect for international humanitarian law should go hand in hand with steps to strengthen accountability for all violations and ensure a survivor-centred and gender-sensitive approach.

Steps at a national level should be complemented with international mechanisms. In that regard, we welcome the continued contribution of the International Criminal Court in Darfur, the Sudan, the Central African Republic and Mali and, since March, in Ukraine, and we support the establishment of the register of damage caused by the aggression of the Russian Federation against Ukraine. Since 2021, when the topic of addressing the impact of conflict on hunger made its way, for the first time, to the Security Council (S/2021/250), there is now an increased shared collective understanding on the short- and long-term impacts of conflict on food systems and on varying impacts on women, girls, boys and men.

Bulgaria is of the view that strengthening the operationalization of resolution 2417 (2018), including through enhanced political leadership and the standardization of reporting, is fundamental to enable

the Security Council to take decisive action and to come up with solutions. A further step to promote a more systematic implementation of existing frameworks and instruments would be the implementation of the proposal for a regular submission of white papers on conflict and hunger to the Security Council and for the appointment of a dedicated focal point in the Secretariat to coordinate and lead the reporting efforts under resolution 2417 (2018).

Bulgaria emphasizes with deep concern that ongoing military conflicts have a devastating impact on indispensable civilian infrastructure and reaffirms its support for resolution 2573 (2021). We call on all parties to give full effect to its provisions, especially given the numerous damages to electricity, health care, water and sanitation infrastructure and the catastrophic threat emanating from hostilities in and around the Zaporizhzhya power plant.

In conclusion, the protection of civilians in armed conflict will continue to rank high among Bulgaria's priorities, and we call on all States and all parties to conflict, including non-State armed groups, to prioritize the protection of civilians and to fully apply the laws and tools we have at our disposal to achieve same.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Colombia.

Mrs. Zalabata Torres (Colombia) (*spoke in Spanish*): For Colombia, food security and sovereignty, and guaranteeing the human right to food, are sine qua non conditions for achieving total peace and sustainable development. The global fight against hunger is an action aimed at preventing the emergence of armed, civil and social conflicts. This fight addresses one of the main sources of conflicts with a view to eradicating them at their root and is based on the inescapable link between peacekeeping and development.

Colombia insists that there is no peace without development and no development without peace. We believe that the Security Council must ensure multilateral action to reinforce this approach as an integral part of its mandate in favour of the protection of civilians and the comprehensive care of populations exposed to higher levels of vulnerability. A sustainable solution to this fight implies the eradication of poverty in all its dimensions and the closing of the inequality gap by strengthening the productive capacities of historically marginalized populations, particularly

rural women, youth, people living in rural communities, indigenous peoples and communities comprised of people of African descent.

The Government of President Gustavo Petro Urrego is fully committed to the objectives outlined just now, for which it has sought to accelerate the implementation of the comprehensive rural reform contained in the Peace Agreement signed in 2016 with the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia-Ejército del Pueblo. As of March 2023, the Colombian State had invested more than \$4.8 million to acquire more than 3,500 hectares of fertile land in order to directly benefit 6,195 rural families. Making progress in these efforts requires a renewed social contract in which the State, the private sector and major landowners work collaboratively to increase agricultural productivity in our country under sustainable models that contribute to the fight against climate change and provide means of production and technology to rural communities.

Colombia also highlights the support of United Nations agencies for national efforts to strengthen resilient agrifood systems. In January 2023, we signed with the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations the Letter of Intent on the Pact for Peace, Food Security and the Human Right to Food to provide a robust framework of technical collaboration for the agency to assist the country in achieving fundamental objectives of its National Development Plan 2022–2026, inter alia, territorial planning around water and the empowerment of rural women.

This conception of territorial planning is based on identifying and enhancing the socioeconomic system connectivity present in Colombia as a result of its vast biological and cultural diversity, which must also be protected in the context of armed conflicts. In this regard, measures to make progress towards guaranteeing the human right to food must overcome the mercantile dynamics of land exploitation and food commercialization and seek to ensure that all communities have sufficient, adequate and healthy food progressively leading to food sovereignty.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Qatar.

Ms. Al-Thani (Qatar) (*spoke in Arabic*): I congratulate your friendly country, Madam President, on assuming the presidency of the Security Council this month. We welcome the convening of today's meeting under the presidency of His Excellency Mr. Alain

Berset, President of the Swiss Confederation. We thank the Secretary-General, the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross and the President of the Network of Women-led Organizations of the Lake Chad Basin for their briefings earlier today.

The protection of civilians is one of the issues at the top of the Security Council's agenda, in view of the Council's mandate to maintain international peace and security. This means that we must avoid civilians being exposed to violence, killing, displacement and the very serious violations that strike at their dignity and safety, including those that stem from food insecurity and lack of essential services caused by conflicts. Accordingly, we welcome the fact that the Security Council adopted two key resolutions on this issue of paramount importance: resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021). We would like to highlight the importance of implementing all of the provisions of both resolutions in all circumstances and by all parties to conflict.

There is no doubt that the ideal way to keep civilians from having to undergo different types of human suffering as a result of conflicts is to prevent conflicts or settle them. However, in the absence of finding a solution, parties to conflicts must uphold the provisions of international humanitarian law. They must prevent the starvation of civilians or the targeting of civilian objects necessary for the water delivery, food production and distribution, and the provision of energy, health care and education. Parties to conflict must guarantee the freedom of movement of civilians and access to humanitarian assistance without obstacles and in the fastest possible manner.

Qatar makes efforts in various fields aimed at promoting the protection of civilians in times of conflict, especially through its unrelenting endeavours to achieve peace, stability and security. Our foreign policy is underpinned by the principle of the peaceful settlement of conflicts, and we support all initiatives that strive to ensure that all perpetrators of crimes against civilians are held to account to avoid their recurrence.

We attach great importance to promoting the protection of education, which is why we co-sponsored the General Assembly resolution 74/275, which proclaims 9 September the International Day to Protect Education from Attack, and urges parties to armed conflicts to respect civilians, including students and educational personnel, and such civilian objects as educational institutions.

Qatar also supports the capacity of the United Nations to swiftly respond to the needs of civilians who have been affected by conflicts through the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs and the Central Emergency Response Fund, to which we have contributed more than \$18 million. We have also extended direct support to efforts aimed at mitigating humanitarian crises. This year, we will be giving \$43 million in response to the Secretary-General's appeal to help meet the needs of all those suffering from famine of various origins, including conflict-induced famine.

Of late, we have seen the terrifying repercussions of the violence against civilians in the Gaza Strip. We have strongly condemned Israel's aggression. We have called on parties to de-escalate, exercise restraint and ensure a return to peace. We have underscored the importance of the international community taking swift action to protect Palestinian civilians and compelling Israel to put an end to its flagrant violations of international law. We have also made efforts to ensure that calm is restored, and the cycle of violence broken. We welcomed the ceasefire that has been agreed.

In our brotherly country, the Sudan, recent events have hit civilians particularly hard. For that reason, Qatar has called on all parties to immediately cease hostilities, heed the voice of wisdom, exercise the greatest restraint and ensure that they act in the general interest of the people, that is, avert civilian suffering from the repercussions of conflict. We have also called for facilitating the delivery of humanitarian assistance to affected populations. This month, we ourselves have sent dozens of tons of urgent food aid to the Sudan after hostilities erupted.

In conclusion, we avail ourselves of this opportunity to stress that Qatar is eager to uphold provisions of international law related to the protection of civilians. We have used all means at our disposal to achieve that objective.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Yemen.

Mr. Al-Saadi (Yemen) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to express our sincere appreciation to Switzerland for holding this important meeting. I also address my appreciation to the Secretary-General and thank him for submitting his report (S/2023/345). I also thank the other briefers for their valuable briefings.

According to the most recent statistics, 21.6 million Yemenis need humanitarian assistance, more than 17 million of whom face severe food shortages. Malnutrition rates among women and children in Yemen remain very high. This bleak picture of the situation in Yemen is the result of the war that the Houthi militia has been waging against the Yemeni people for over eight years. Understanding the causes of food insecurity and the deterioration of basic services in Yemen is a key element in finding a solution. Therefore, allow me to elaborate.

First, one of the main reasons for the food shortage in Yemen is the inability of people to afford the cost of living and the fact that Houthi militias are besieging cities — especially Taiz, with more than 4 million citizens — and starving civilians as a method of war. They continue to loot and refuse to transfer tax and customs revenues, as well as revenue from the port of Al-Hudaydah, to the bank account set up to contribute to paying salaries for employees, in accordance with the Stockholm Agreement.

Secondly, when the international community offered its generous support in the provision of food, nutrition and basic services to the Yemeni people, the acute food shortage suffered by most Yemenis continued, and the United Nations agencies, including the World Food Programme, clearly reported the obstacles imposed by the Houthis to impede the delivery of humanitarian assistance, stealing part of it from the mouths of the hungry, not to mention their imposition of restrictions on female humanitarian workers through the so-called male-guardian system.

Thirdly, even when assistance to Yemen, arriving often via Al-Hudaydah port, eventually passes through those obstacles, it often reaches the camps of some 4 million internally displaced persons (IDPs) too late because the IDPs have had to flee again to other camps as a result of further Houthi military escalation.

Fourthly, the ability of the Yemeni Government to stay resilient in the face of these challenges has been depleted because the national economy has shrunk by half due to war. With continued Houthi attacks on oil ports and facilities, the country has suffered some \$1 billion worth of losses that were allocated to improve public services, paying salaries all over Yemen. Despite this bleak picture, the Yemeni Government has carried out many reforms in order to enable State institutions, like the Central Bank and the Ministry of Finance, to

work effectively to achieve economic recovery and macroeconomic stability. From an early stage, the Government also sought to rebuild the economy and develop the private sector to enable it to better deal with risks and shocks and to raise the income of citizens, create job opportunities and improve food security and nutrition in Yemen.

Fifthly, climate change and the ensuing water scarcity, drought, desertification and destructive floods in some governorates of Yemen, as well as the weakness of water policies, have further deteriorated food security in Yemen. The coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic has also further exacerbated the humanitarian crisis.

The problem of food insecurity in Yemen is further worsened by the effects of tensions and conflicts worldwide, since Yemen imports most of its food. The fragile situation in Yemen is therefore very sensitive to any shock to supply chains and global trade. In that regard, we commend the Black Sea Grain Initiative, which had a significant impact in combating the rise and volatility of prices of basic food supplies, as the initiative enabled the export of more than 15 million tons of food during the past year. In that connection, we reiterate the importance of prioritizing countries in conflict situations and those suffering from food insecurity so as to avoid unfortunate famine and catastrophe.

The United Nations truce, which the Houthi militias refused to extend, provided a ray of hope for the Yemeni people. The Yemeni Government has supported all international and United Nations initiatives and has shown greater flexibility in its attempt to ensure progress that would put an end to the conflict and ease the suffering of the Yemenis, as well as facilitate the work of United Nations agencies and relief organizations and access to commercial imports. We strive to allow Yemenis to have freedom of movement to and from Yemen. However, those efforts are threatened by the Houthis' refusal to deal positively with the peace initiatives and efforts and their refusal to extend the humanitarian truce in order to achieve a comprehensive ceasefire and launch a political process, led by Yemenis and sponsored by the United Nations, to end the conflict.

In conclusion, in the context of achieving the main goal of our meeting today and ensuring that we come with achievable visions and proposals to

promote the necessary protection for civilians and their access to basic services, we would like to stress the following points.

First, we need to pressure the Houthi militias to stop plundering the Yemeni people's resources, to stop their violations, to commit to a truce as a humanitarian priority and to engage in good faith with the United Nations Special Envoy and with the mediation efforts of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and the Sultanate of Oman to reach a just, lasting and sustainable solution to the Yemeni crisis.

The Houthi militias must be pressured to stop targeting the oil facilities and basic infrastructure of Yemen and to stop other violations that jeopardize the peace process and cause economic harm to all Yemenis and deteriorate the humanitarian situation. The Houthis should empower the Government to resume oil exports so that it can meet its urgent financial obligations to citizens, including paying salaries that help the population to cope with difficult living conditions and financing food imports flowing to areas under its control and under the control of the Houthis.

We stress that humanitarian support plays a prominent role in achieving economic stability through using the Central Bank as the main banking establishment, instead of commercial banks or local banking establishments in areas under the control of the Houthi militias, with a view to enhancing the role of national institutions and achieving a stable economy and national currency exchange rate.

Those approaches must be long-term and focused on bolstering the resilience of the most vulnerable segments of society so that they can achieve a level of self-sufficiency and no longer require humanitarian assistance. In that context, we stress the importance of focusing on the relationship between the humanitarian and long-term development aspects in order to enhance the resilience of individuals and communities and create a future where job opportunities contribute to the eradication of poverty and hunger.

We need to incorporate capacity-building aspects and strengthen resilience capacities in all programmes and humanitarian interventions. We must work with the Governments of beneficiary countries to promote their humanitarian capacities and provide modern technologies to develop national programmes to lift up the national economy and create new work opportunities to raise the quality of Government services and the lives of citizens.

We must work on helping the least developed countries, especially those living through conflict or are in a post-conflict situation, to address the effects of climate change based on the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities. We must provide those countries assistance to help mitigate the effects of COVID-19, as part of the loss and damage fund recently approved, and benefit from other climate-change-reparation initiatives. We must also ensure the continuity of supply chains and the flow of food commodities, fight inflation and price increase in order to safeguard the security and dignity of civilians. I apologize for the length of my statement.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Guatemala.

Ms. Rodríguez Mancia (Guatemala) (*spoke in Spanish*): Guatemala thanks the Swiss Confederation for convening this timely open debate and the panellists for their briefings.

Guatemala shares the views expressed in the concept note (S/2023/307, annex), in the sense that civilians continue to be the most affected by armed conflicts, especially women and children. It is regrettable that conflicts continue to be the main factor of food insecurity and displacement, aggravated by the growing crises, including climate change.

We call the attention of all States to their commitment to the application of international humanitarian law in armed conflict. Experience has shown us that the use of explosive weapons in populated areas causes serious harm to civilians and affects services essential to their survival.

The security environment of peacekeeping missions is increasingly volatile and requires a readjustment of the mandates of the Council in order to meet real needs, especially those related to the protection of civilians. It is necessary for the actors involved, in particular troop-contributing countries and the United Nations Secretariat, to review the rules of engagement so as to ensure that they are updated and properly aligned.

There is a need to recognize the importance of integrated, coordinated and comprehensive approaches to mandate implementation. The Security Council must take into account assessments of the threat of violence against civilians in the operational planning and decision-making processes that determine when and where peacekeeping operation capabilities will be

deployed and—in the General Assembly’s assessment of the mandate, as well as in the Fifth Committee—where the necessary resources must be approved.

Guatemala makes an urgent call to address the hunger crisis as one of the priorities of the international agenda. We recognize the work carried out by the World Food Programme and reiterate the importance of guaranteeing the protection of humanitarian personnel in the field.

International cooperation must have a preventive and not only reactive approach, addressing the root causes of hunger from a holistic perspective. We are therefore preparing for the 2023 United Nations Food Systems Stocktaking Moment and stress the importance of the coordinated work of the United Nations system, in cooperation with regional and national organizations.

We reiterate our support for the recommendations of the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations regarding keeping open trade in food and agricultural goods, promoting local production and technology transfer. National ownership is key to ensuring sustainability, improving transparency and strengthening institutions.

We highly appreciate that the Security Council supports early warning systems to provide Governments and humanitarian actors with timely, reliable, accurate and verifiable information to prevent and mitigate the effects of a food crisis in the context of an armed conflict.

We follow with interest the implementation of the recommendations of the Global Crisis Response Group on Food, Energy and Finance, of which the Security Council is a part, and the renewal process of the Black Sea Grain Initiative and the Joint Coordination Centre, which are multilateral efforts to mitigate the devastating consequences of the Russian Federation’s illegal, unjustified and unprovoked aggression against Ukraine.

We call for peace and justice, focusing on the fight against poverty, hunger and climate change, ensuring the life and development of our peoples, with a view to achieving the New Agenda for Peace.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Spain.

Ms. Jimenez de la Hoz (Spain) (*spoke in Spanish*): Spain aligns itself with the statement made by the representative of the European Union, as well as

those made on behalf of the Group of Friends on the Protection of Civilians and the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect. I would also like to make some additional remarks in my national capacity.

At the outset, I would like to wholeheartedly thank the Swiss presidency for convening this high-level open debate. Attacks on populations and critical infrastructure— from hospitals and schools to water storage systems, food or power generators— are, unfortunately, commonplace in contexts such as Afghanistan, Syria, Mali or, of course, Ukraine.

But Ukraine is not only an example of the horrors faced by civilians in conflict contexts, but it also shows how conflicts can have global humanitarian repercussions, in this case through food insecurity. In that regard, we welcome the two-month renewal of the Black Sea Grain Initiative and commend the Secretary-General for his mediation efforts.

The Secretary-General’s report on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345) notes that, in 2022, 174 health workers lost their lives in attacks, most of them in Ukraine. That is unacceptable. We call for compliance with resolution 2286 (2016), which Spain promoted in 2016, on the protection of hospitals, ambulances and health workers in conflict.

The report also shows how women and girls continue to be particularly exposed to sexual violence in conflict. It is therefore essential to support preventive approaches and women’s participation in decision-making spaces, including in the humanitarian response to armed conflict, in line with the women and peace and security agenda.

Attacks on schools and teachers not only continued, but increased in 2022. We will continue to promote support for the Safe Schools Declaration, which in May was endorsed by Guyana, to reach 118 signatory countries, and encourage all countries that have not signed it yet, to do so.

We also encourage countries that have not yet joined the Political Declaration on the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas to do so. We must integrate the content of the Political Declaration into the practice of our armed forces so as to ensure effective protection of civilians in conflict.

I would like to conclude by stressing that Spain recently approved its first humanitarian diplomacy strategy for the period 2023-2026 in order to provide

a more coordinated and effective response to growing humanitarian needs. This document addresses all these issues, from hunger in armed conflicts and the fight against impunity, to care for refugees and internally displaced persons and the protection of persons with disabilities in conflict situations.

Finally, beginning on 1 July, my country will also take over the presidency of the Council of the European Union, where humanitarian issues will be very present, and we will continue to advocate for the protection of civilians and full respect for international humanitarian law.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Dominican Republic.

Ms. Carlson (Dominican Republic) (*spoke in Spanish*): First, the Dominican Republic thanks Switzerland for convening this open debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict. We appreciate and welcome the presentation of the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/345) and take note of his recommendations.

The Dominican Republic aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Ireland, on behalf of the Group of Friends of Action on Conflict and Hunger, and by the representative of Kuwait, on behalf of the Group of Friends on the Protection of Civilians.

This year marks five years since the Security Council unanimously adopted resolution 2417 (2018) as a sign of its concern and resolve to address one of the most relevant issues in the context of armed conflict. In 2020, under the leadership of the Dominican Republic, the Council adopted a presidential statement S/PRST/2020/6, which gave new impetus to this issue and broadened its scope by emphasizing the need for early warning as a way to facilitate the Security Council's action in a timely manner.

Regrettably, however, the reality is that much remains to be done in this area. Despite the warnings and alarms, the Security Council has, at times, been paralysed from taking the necessary action to ensure the protection of civilians from hunger and destitution. Hunger is still used as a weapon in conflicts, at the expense of vulnerable populations, in full view of all.

The Dominican Republic reiterates once again — we need a paradigm shift that forces us to anticipate, prevent and better respond to the causes of food insecurity and famine caused by violence,

conflicts and humanitarian crises. We therefore need to invest in proactive action, full respect for international humanitarian law, peacebuilding and resilient livelihoods to prevent humanitarian crises from turning into catastrophes. But, above all, we must increase political will to use the tools at our disposal and with the necessary decisiveness at the right time.

We must recommit to the full implementation of resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), as well as presidential statement S/PRST/2020/6, in particular by protecting assets indispensable to the survival of civilians, by taking constant care to preserve civilians and civilian objects and by facilitating the rapid and unimpeded passage of impartial humanitarian relief to all those in need.

Conflict and violence are the main causes of hunger. That is why we need to break the vicious cycle of armed conflict and food insecurity, find political solutions to conflicts and support integrated responses to address the multiple drivers.

The world is not on track to end hunger by 2030. We therefore reiterate that the cost of inaction would be even greater for all countries of the world if we do not act now.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of El Salvador.

Mrs. González López (El Salvador) (*spoke in Spanish*): Let me express my gratitude to the Swiss presidency for its leadership in organizing and convening this debate on ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in conflict, which presents a unique opportunity to address food insecurity and the protection of essential services. We also thank all briefers for their presentations.

El Salvador regrets that, five years after the adoption of resolution 2417 (2018), more than 250 million people have suffered from acute hunger in more than 50 countries and territories, in many of which the civilian population is also facing armed conflict and insecurity.

We also regret that, two years after the adoption of resolution 2573 (2021), critical infrastructure, in particular those enabling the provision of energy, health care, water and sanitation services, suffered extensive damage as a result of armed conflict, disrupting access for civilians.

We are deeply concerned that conflict continues to destroy or disable civilian infrastructure and assets essential for livelihoods, food security and survival. Millions of people have been deprived of safe drinking water and have been exposed to contamination, deadly disease outbreaks and serious malnutrition risks. I would like to emphasize that this is about the well-being of people who trust the United Nations and hope that they will be supported and kept safe, above all, in conflict situations.

The destruction of civilian infrastructure, such as agricultural systems and transport networks, only increases the suffering of civilians — again, these are people — reducing their access to basic services such as health, water, sanitation, electricity and communications, blurring the line of the principle of distinction of international humanitarian law.

El Salvador therefore recognizes the direct link between armed conflict and food insecurity, which increases the vulnerability of millions of people and highlights underlying humanitarian needs. Civilians in armed conflict and those forcibly displaced suffer first-hand the devastating impacts of war and violence.

We deplore that in contexts of conflict, civilians are deliberately or indirectly prevented from obtaining food and water and that access to humanitarian assistance is impeded — in extreme cases, as a result of attacks on humanitarian workers and assets.

All of that is compounded by the devastating effects of climate change and extreme weather events, such as droughts and heavy rains, which have significantly worsened food security globally, including in countries in conflict. It is clear that there is much to be done. That has been noted and repeated in the various country statements delivered here. We must do much more to protect the population and to prevent and combat hunger in conflicts, but that requires an urgent and cohesive response from the United Nations system, as well as the political will of all the States Members of the United Nations.

El Salvador takes this opportunity to express its full support for resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021) and reiterates the need to redouble efforts for their full implementation and compliance. They must be put into practice and not just remain on paper. We must honour our responsibility to ensure the well-being of all people, especially the most vulnerable.

As a troop- and police-contributing country, El Salvador recognizes the fundamental role played by United Nations peacekeeping operations and special political missions in preventing and reducing acts of violence against the civilian population. My country reiterates its firm commitment to the implementation of civilian protection mandates in peacekeeping operations.

The States Members of the United Nations and other organizations working to ensure respect for the principles of international humanitarian law need to redouble their efforts on the ground — and I will not tire of saying this — in order to ensure civilian protection and food security. Let us work together.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Kenya.

Ms. Kinyungu (Kenya): I express our gratitude to the delegation of Switzerland for initiating this important debate.

Joining other delegations, Kenya strongly condemns any act of targeting civilians or civilian infrastructure. We affirm the paramount necessity for combatants to adhere to international humanitarian law and associated norms that safeguard civilians amid armed conflict.

War, inherently, disregards dignity. The foremost protection for civilians' dignity and security does not lie in the conduct of war, but in its prevention. Should a conflict erupt, prompt, competent and decisive action to mediate a ceasefire and facilitate negotiated peace becomes indispensable.

Paradoxically, frequent emphasis on norm observance during conflicts may inadvertently validate them. This comes from the erroneous belief that war can be clinical — an illusion that has repeatedly drawn us into repeated and extraordinarily costly elective wars in recent decades.

I present the following recommendations for the Council's consideration.

First, the Secretary-General's good offices must be respected by States, which should embrace their independence and avail themselves more readily of those offices. These efforts should be led by competent, qualified and courageous leadership.

Secondly, war often precipitates hunger and starvation, even when not weaponized. While we denounce attacks on civilian resources crucial for food security, we must also enable humanitarian interventions that bolster local production and livelihoods.

Thirdly, it is crucial to establish a strong bridge between humanitarian aid, development and peacebuilding. In addition, the international financial institutions should further strive to mitigate investment risks in fragile post-conflict regions, which typically struggle to secure traditional investment.

Fourthly, we must prevent escalation towards major Power conflicts, which inevitably result in proxy wars and expose civilians to harm. We must collectively demand that major Powers, with their far-reaching economic, political and military influence, exhibit responsible statesmanship to establish a balanced and stable multipolar world. They can recognize and embrace their own long-term interest in upholding robust multilateralism, whose laws and agreements constrain the powerful, rather than today's tattered multilateralism in which — with every passing act of great power — impunity becomes a facade for a brutal Darwinian international system.

In conclusion, I reaffirm Kenya's commitment to enhancing civilian protection in situations of armed conflict and to addressing the grave challenge of food insecurity.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Nepal.

Mr. Aryal (Nepal): I thank the presidency of Switzerland for convening today's open debate. We thank the briefers for their comprehensive and insightful briefings this morning.

The protection of civilians is at the core of the work and purposes of the United Nations. However, the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/345) presents a gloomy picture of around 17,000 civilian deaths across 12 armed conflicts in 2022, which is a 53 per cent increase compared to 2021. Both the State and non-State actors have violated the international normative frameworks and laws of armed conflict.

Civilian infrastructure and assets essential to people's livelihoods and survival, including food systems, health care, water and electricity services have been attacked purposefully. The rise in the prices of food, fuel and fertilizers, combined with the effects of climate change, has intensified civilians' suffering. More than a quarter of a billion people are now facing acute levels of hunger.

The Ukraine crisis has further worsened food and energy insecurity. The mounting food and oil prices

have hit the least developed countries such as Nepal and their most vulnerable populations, including women and children.

Resolution 2417 (2018) has recognized the links between conflict and food insecurity. Similarly, resolution 2573 (2021) recognizes the indispensability of the protection of civilian infrastructure.

Compliance with applicable international laws and international humanitarian laws, including Security Council resolutions, is essential for mitigating conflict-induced food insecurity, banning starvation as a weapon of war and protecting civilian infrastructure alongside ensuring access to humanitarian aid. We need to ensure accountability for the violation of such a normative/legal framework. We also need to improve the identification of critical infrastructure and update no-strike lists.

The State has the primary responsibility to protect its civilians. Therefore, the capacity of the national Government should be strengthened for the implementation of international humanitarian, human rights, criminal and refugee law. The primacy of politics and the preference for preventive diplomacy should be upheld.

We need to address the root causes of conflicts, including through supporting vulnerable countries for their economic development.

While prioritizing conflict-affected zones, we should address food insecurity by building a sustainable, resilient and inclusive food system at the national and global levels.

Nepal remains supportive of the United Nations normative framework and holistic approach to protecting civilians in armed conflict. Currently, as the second largest troop-and-police contributing country, Nepal is contributing to protecting civilians in the most volatile parts of the world. However, the protection of civilian mandate should be equipped with adequate financial, human and technological resources.

There is a need for urgent action to protect civilians and essential services before situations turn into a humanitarian disaster on a vast scale. We call on all parties concerned to respect the rules and do the right thing.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Israel.

Mr. Miller (Israel): The past year has demonstrated to the international community the importance of the protection of civilians as a key tenet of our shared values.

For Israel specifically, as a nation faced with unrelenting security threats since its founding 75 years ago, the protection of civilians in armed conflict is of utmost importance. Israel remains committed to the provision of humanitarian aid across the globe and shares the concern of other Member States regarding the impact of armed conflicts on global food security, as well as the intentional targeting of critical civilian infrastructure.

The protection of civilians must be at the forefront of any armed conflict. Nevertheless, our enemies do exactly the opposite. Earlier this month, more than 1,400 rockets were indiscriminately launched by the Palestinian Islamic Jihad, a globally recognized terror organization, at Israeli towns and cities. That came weeks after a barrage of 34 missiles were fired at Israel from southern Lebanon, where Hizbullah continues to increase its presence unabated, while bluntly violating numerous Security Council resolutions, placing the lives of both Israeli and Lebanese civilians at risk. During that last blatant terror rocket attacks, several Israelis were injured, and one Israeli, 82-year-old Inga Avramyan, a loving wife, mother and grandmother, was murdered.

While Israel goes above the letter of the law to protect the lives of civilians, those who seek Israel's destruction intentionally target Israeli civilians while using Palestinian and Lebanese civilians as human shields. They hide their rockets among the local population, use private residences as situation rooms and utilize dense urban areas as rocket launchpads.

In addition, during the recent Operation Shield and Arrow two weeks ago, roughly one of every five rockets fired by the Palestinian Islamic Jihad at Israel misfired and fell into Gaza. Several of those misfired rockets killed at least two Palestinian children, Yazan Elayyan, 16 years old, and Layan Madoukh, 8 years old. That is the result when terrorists purposely fire rockets at Israeli civilians from populated civilian areas. Everyone is at risk of being killed. There is no more serious crime.

Targeting civilians while using civilians for cover is not only unthinkable, it also a double war crime, and the international community remains silent. For Israel, the value of human life is paramount. And we

take every effort to protect the lives of both our own population, as well as others. In that regard, Israel harnesses innovation and creativity in developing groundbreaking defensive technologies, such as the Iron Dome and Iron Beam, to save countless lives.

Two weeks ago, as rockets rained down on Israel, the Iron Dome and other defensive measures intercepted 371 rockets launched at our civilians. That directly prevented a catastrophic loss of life and damage to civilian infrastructure. While Hamas, Palestinian Islamic Jihad, Hizbullah and other terror proxies of the Iranian regime invest in murdering civilians, Israel invests in protecting them.

Terrorist groups used their murderous attacks as an opportunity to obstruct that aid at the expense of Palestinian civilians. Terror groups in Gaza repeatedly target areas adjacent to crossings in and out of the Gaza Strip. Those attacks forced the closure of those crossings, preventing the passage of aid, but also the passage of Palestinian civilians, including children, in need of critical medical treatment in Israel. That was true two weeks ago when Palestinian Islamic Jihad was firing rockets in Israel and also two years ago when Hamas indiscriminately launched over 4,000 rockets at Israel. Humanitarian aid cannot ever be a target under international law, and any act that obstructs or hinders humanitarian access must be condemned in the strongest terms.

While Israel takes every measure to protect the lives of the innocent, its enemies act in the exact opposite way. We use our missiles to protect our children while they use their children to protect their missiles. Indiscriminate rocket fire on civilian populations and the use of one's own people as human shields must be condemned. But more than that, it must end. We urge all delegations to join us in condemning those heinous acts of terror from Hizbullah, Hamas, Palestinian Islamic Jihad and all terror organizations that seek to kill Israeli civilians.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of San Marino.

Mr. Beleffi (San Marino): I would like to thank you, Madam President, for convening this very important meeting, and I would like to thank the briefers for their statements.

Armed conflicts cause an unacceptable number of casualties among civilians. Civilians are often

wounded. They must flee their homes. They suffer from a lack of food and the destruction of their houses and vital infrastructure.

San Marino is alarmed by the unprecedented food and nutrition crisis caused by all conflicts and affecting hundreds of millions of people around the world. The levels of malnutrition, food insecurity and risk of famine can only increase when hostilities are protracted.

We are concerned about the direct and indirect consequences of hostilities on food systems, water and electricity infrastructure, sanitation and health care. Some Marino calls on all parties to implement resolution 2417 (2018), which condemns the use of the starvation of civilians as a method of warfare, as well as the unlawful denial of humanitarian access. Furthermore, San Marino supports resolution 2573 (2021), which condemns attacks against critical civilian infrastructure indispensable to the survival of the civilian population. In that regard, we welcome the adoption of the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas.

The Republic of San Marino is deeply concerned about the condition of vulnerable groups in armed conflict. Many children suffer grave violations and abuses. They are deprived of their basic rights, such as education, after schools are attacked, destroyed or used as military facilities. In that regard, San Marino has joined important instruments that are aimed at protecting children in conflict, as well as their rehabilitation and reintegration, such as the Safe Schools Declaration, the Paris Principles and the Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers.

The possibility that persons with disabilities living in conflict areas might be unable to flee attacks and might be abandoned is another concern for San Marino. Moreover, the disruption of basic services in those areas deprives them of their basic needs. It is therefore critical to act effectively together for the protection of those specific groups.

Once again, I want to reiterate the critical importance of international humanitarian law. All parties must strictly abide by those norms, and we need to support measures to ensure accountability for violators. Political mediation, early warning mechanisms and actual policies and practices are also

needed for effective protection of civilians. Only with the genuine commitment of all parties and stakeholders will we finally be able to safeguard civilians in armed conflict.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Malaysia.

Mr. Muhamad (Malaysia): I thank you, Madam President, for convening today's important debate. I also thank the briefers for their invaluable insights.

Exactly five years ago, the Security Council adopted resolution 2417 (2018), which condemns the use of starvation of civilians as a method of warfare in armed conflicts. The briefing today reaffirms that it continues to be a grave concern. We must use this opportunity to address the issue constructively and focus our efforts towards fully implementing the relevant Security Council resolutions, particularly resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021).

Our delegation condemns violent attacks on civilians in armed conflicts. Sadly, in many parts of the world — for example, in Palestine and Myanmar — protracted violence has caused massive destruction and immense suffering to innocent civilians, many of whom are women and children. The hardship faced by civilians caught in armed conflicts typically includes food insecurity, malnutrition and a general lack of access to basic necessities.

In that regard, my delegation wishes to stress the following points.

First, Malaysia believes in peaceful and negotiated solutions to armed conflicts. We continue to call on Member States, particularly Council members, to honour the commitment made in supporting the Secretary-General's call for a global ceasefire in 2020.

Secondly, Malaysia considers United Nations peacekeeping operations an indispensable instrument in the protection of civilians in armed conflicts. In some places, the peacekeepers have participated in projects to enhance food security in local communities. For example, Malaysian peacekeepers, through a quick-impact project of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon, have contributed to enhancing food security by helping local communities to build agricultural infrastructure. We should do more to explore such possibilities.

Finally, we reiterate our call for all parties to conflict to adhere to the applicable norms of international humanitarian and human rights law, as well as to respect and earnestly implement United Nations resolutions. States must uphold their obligations to protect the life, health and dignity of civilians in times of conflict, especially those of vulnerable groups such as children, women, the elderly and those with disabilities.

Regrettably, 77 years after we made the promise to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war, armed conflicts continue raging in many parts of the world, inflicting great human suffering. While we continue striving to end armed conflict, we must do more to uphold international humanitarian law and implement relevant United Nations resolutions to ensure the protection of civilians. Malaysia will continue to do its part in contributing constructively to that endeavour.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Bangladesh.

Mr. Muhith (Bangladesh): I thank you, Madam President, for convening this important debate today. I also thank the Secretary-General, the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross and the other briefers for their insightful presentations.

My delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the Group of Friends on the Protection of Civilians and the statement delivered on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

Having experienced the devastation of war in 1971 and its consequences for innocent civilians during and after the war, Bangladesh remains deeply committed to the protection of civilians. Our commitment is well manifested in the contributions of our men and women serving as Blue Helmets in various conflict-affected parts of the world. It is in the same spirit that our Government opened its border to more than 1 million Rohingya minorities when they fled atrocities in Myanmar.

During conflict, civilians suffer the most. Their sufferings are exacerbated when there are attacks on essential services or infrastructure. Such attacks can lead to food insecurity and displacement. Those irresponsible acts also have long-term impacts on those countries, making post-conflict rebuilding even more challenging.

As mentioned in the report of the Secretary General (S/2023/345), conflict and food insecurity have been the most significant drivers of high levels of acute food insecurity for approximately 117 million people in 19 countries and territories. And the causes of conflict-induced food insecurity in those and other conflict situations include direct harm to food and water sources, as well as impediments to food and water production, delivery and access.

Allow me to share a few thoughts on today's topic.

First, with primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security, the Security Council has a major role to play in addressing conflict-induced food insecurity and protecting essential services. In that regard, we recall resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021) and seek their full implementation. It is equally important to ensure respect for and full compliance with international humanitarian law by all parties to conflict.

Secondly, when conflicts cause food insecurity and hunger, often the only way for civilians to survive is by gaining access to humanitarian aid. Ensuring unimpeded access for the people in need and the safety of humanitarian personnel, including national staff, is critical for the protection of civilians during armed conflicts.

In that regard, we also wish to emphasize the importance of ensuring the delivery of humanitarian aid to all communities irrespective of race, religion or belief. We are concerned that, in Myanmar, Rohingya Muslims are facing obstacles in their ability to access humanitarian aid in the aftermath of Cyclone Mocha. Such discrimination may lead to their further displacement.

Thirdly, we are concerned about the impact of conflict on the environment. Environmental hazards resulting from the destruction of critical infrastructure may have a long-term effect on the climate and the lives of the people in conflict settings. Besides, conflict-related food insecurity exacerbates the sufferings of people living with existing vulnerabilities, including those caused by climate change, drought, floods and other natural disasters. Those need to be adequately factored in while responding to food insecurity and also in addressing their root causes.

Fourthly, peacekeeping missions play a crucial role in protecting civilians in conflict-affected settings, including by providing security to critical civilian infrastructure and also during the delivery of

humanitarian aid. The Council needs to also enable and empower the peacekeeping missions with necessary resources and capabilities for effective implementation of their protection of civilians mandate.

Women often suffer the most when conflict strikes and causes food insecurity. Women can, however, also play a critical role in addressing food insecurity, including in post-conflict settings. Numerous Council resolutions on women and peace and security have recognized that. We therefore reiterate our call for stronger efforts for the implementation of the women and peace and security agenda.

In conclusion, I reiterate Bangladesh's commitment to the protection of civilians. We will continue to contribute to the protection of civilian mandate of the United Nations through peacekeeping operations and other forms of engagement.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Nigeria.

Ms. Dakwak (Nigeria): I thank the Permanent Mission of Switzerland and Council President for the month for organizing this very important debate on the theme "Ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in conflict: addressing food insecurity and protecting essential services". My delegation also thanks His Excellency Mr. Alain Berset, President of the Swiss Confederation, for chairing the debate. Permit me to also express my delegation's sincere appreciation to the Secretary-General of the United Nations, His Excellency Mr. António Guterres; the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross and Ms. Aïchatou Mounkaïla for their briefings. My delegation aligns itself with the statement delivered on behalf of the Group of Friends of the Responsibility to Protect.

The theme is a reminder of the susceptibility of the population to food insecurity in times of conflict and the need to take collective action to address some of that and related challenges. Conflict has cost the lives of thousands of defenceless civilians, and many more are caught up in the web of conflict-induced crises even as we are gathered here today.

Many civilians have been displaced by conflicts, losing their dignity with the destruction of their homes and livelihoods, including the loss of family life, as well as essential facilities and infrastructure. In many conflicts, especially in Africa, insurgency and

terrorism further compound the situation. With those, we often are confronted with the proliferation of small arms and light weapons, with the resultant effects of the exacerbation of conflict and the loss of lives of locals and humanitarian workers.

The widespread availability and misuse of illicit weapons have resulted in the displacement of hundreds of thousands of civilians, many injured, women raped and many killed in attacks. Weapons are so easy to obtain, armed violence is so prevalent and humanitarian assistance is frequently suspended or delayed. Under such circumstances, human rights violations, including of international humanitarian law, have become widespread. We must address that menace and control the movement of weapons and uphold international humanitarian law norms.

Food insecurity has been associated with many recent conflicts. Conflict has been a major factor behind the disruption of food systems and the destruction of the means of livelihoods and more. As in many situations, the impact has been more severe on the poor who are dependent on farming for food and other resources. My delegation notes with concern the reports of the World Food Programme and the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations which point out that 70 per cent of the world's population experiencing acute hunger is in conflict-affected areas.

In Africa, the Ukraine war is adversely affecting the food supply chain, further exacerbating pre-existing food insecurity which in some cases stems from terrorism. The reduction or even stoppage of agricultural activities due to insecurity and displacement has also led to other terrible consequences. Violent conflict must be stopped, and in all cases priority should be given to the protection of the civilian population.

A recent United Nations report projects that the African population will rise to approximately 3.8 billion by the year 2100. Given the all-too-familiar siphoning of Africa's resources through an unfair international trading system, corruption and other factors, a serious normative and institutional look at that situation is called for by both the African States and international community.

Women and children are the most vulnerable in civilian casualties. And it is well known that women rarely initiate violent conflicts, yet they suffer its worst consequences on multiple fronts: physically, psychologically, economically, socially and politically.

Often, women fall victim to predatory warlords who systematically use rape and sexual violence as a weapon of war. Women's suffering is compounded by their exclusion from key decision-making processes that might enhance peace and stability. We must therefore redouble our efforts and engage in new and creative thinking to resolve persistent gaps and structural barriers to women's participation and leadership, as well as in the delivery of humanitarian assistance. That can be done, among other ways, through the crafting of women's protection subsystems ensuring full participation of women in all societal processes whether in war or in peace.

As we prepare for the Sustainable Development Goals summit this September and the summit of the future next year, it is pertinent that the international community demonstrate more commitment to the repatriation of illicit financial flows and assets, debt relief for developing countries and assistance towards the modernization of agriculture in Africa.

Nigeria remains unwavering in its commitment to ensuring the dignity and the security of civilians in conflict and working alongside all Member States to uphold all international and human rights, including humanitarian law. In addition, Nigeria is also committed to addressing food insecurity and provision and the protection of essential services for civilians in conflicts.

My delegation hopes that our discussions today will serve as a catalyst that will translate to concrete action for a paradigmatic shift towards economic equity and fairness, the reduction of conflicts, the safety of civilians and a much-needed food security for all and sundry, especially in situations of conflict.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Italy.

Mr. Greco (Italy): Italy aligns itself with the statements delivered on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends on the Protection of Civilians.

We would like to thank the Swiss presidency of the Security Council for organizing this annual open debate on the protection of civilians in armed conflict with a specific focus on the urgent issues of food insecurity and the safeguarding of essential services.

Today those topics are more urgent and alarming than ever before. The devastating impacts on civilians caused by the illegal Russian military aggression

on Ukraine, which we strongly condemn, and the indirect consequences of that heinous aggression on the global food security crisis are a stark reminder of the crucial importance of respecting international humanitarian law.

Respecting international humanitarian law is paramount in preventing hunger during conflicts and safeguarding the lives of civilians. As we all know, international humanitarian law explicitly prohibits the use of starvation as a method of warfare and provides special protection for objects essential to the survival of civilian populations.

The annual report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/345) further emphasizes the gravity of conflict-induced food insecurity and the critical need to protect vital civilian infrastructure and essential services. We must reflect on the implementation of resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021), which can play a significant role in addressing conflict-related hunger and ensuring the safety of essential services.

Italy, as the host country of the Rome-based United Nations food agencies, is particularly committed to addressing the critical issue of global food insecurity. In that context, the recent renewal of the Black Sea Grain Initiative remains a beacon of hope for maintaining open food chains and lowering and stabilizing global food prices. We strongly support the efforts of the Secretary-General and Under Secretary-General Griffiths in that regard.

Furthermore, Italy recognizes the urgency of providing vital assistance to other humanitarian crises in the global South. Tomorrow, we will be hosting a humanitarian pledging conference on the Horn of Africa in collaboration with the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, the United States, the United Kingdom and Qatar. We kindly encourage the high-level participation and substantial financial contributions of Member States to support that important initiative.

In addition, as the Chair of the humanitarian affairs segment of the Economic and Social Council, Italy has identified food insecurity as a key theme this year. In collaboration with Kenya, we are co-facilitating the annual humanitarian resolution aimed at reinforcing the language on food security and addressing protection risks.

Let me also highlight that Italy is honoured to host the upcoming stock-taking moment of the United Nations Food Systems summit in Rome in July 2023.

This event will provide a valuable opportunity to assess innovative and inclusive solutions to address the complex challenges of food security.

In conclusion, we urge the international community to redouble its efforts and take decisive action to address the pressing challenges of food insecurity, protect essential services and create a safer and more dignified future for all civilians affected by conflicts worldwide. Italy is ready to do its part.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Morocco.

Mr. Lahsaini (Morocco): I would like to thank the Permanent Mission of Switzerland for convening and presiding over this important meeting.

The interest of the Kingdom of Morocco in promoting security, combating hunger and fostering sustainable agriculture emanates from a deep awareness of the challenges of food security in the world in general and on the African continent in particular. According to the *Global Report on Food Crises 2023*, armed conflict and other threats to security pushed 139 million people, especially in Africa, into acute food insecurity in 2021, which represents an increase of almost 40 million people compared to the year before. In 2023, the situation has gotten worse. The effects of climate change, the impact of the coronavirus disease and current geopolitical tensions are felt across the globe. Inflation and debts heavily affect domestic food productivity.

In 30 years, Africa will have to feed twice its current population. Unfortunately, the continent continues to import over \$43 billion in food annually, net, and therefore remains dependent on imports to feed its growing population. This situation has major repercussions for the stability of the most vulnerable countries, as the scarcity of resources and the sudden increase in food prices fuels social unrest. In this vein, allow me to share with the Security Council a few perspectives from Morocco on how to better ensure the security and dignity of civilians in conflict, especially in addressing food insecurity and protecting essential services.

First, it is evident that conflicts, especially on a large scale and of long duration, have a direct impact on food security, not only where the fighting takes place, but often also in neighbouring countries and beyond. It is therefore important to help mitigate the impacts of armed conflict on food security by

avoiding the destruction of crops, agricultural land and critical infrastructure. When such destruction occurs, starvation of civilians becomes a huge humanitarian challenge — hence the importance of protecting the infrastructure necessary to produce food and drinking water, especially in conflict areas.

Secondly, international cooperation needs to prepare rapid response plans and coordinate anticipatory action to reinforce weak points in conflict zones. This requires in-depth knowledge of the evolving local challenges that civilians in conflicts face and therefore necessitates the involvement of local stakeholders that are the closest to the population. In this vein, partnerships and collaboration between local actors and international humanitarian organizations is paramount.

Thirdly, sustainable change in the global food and agriculture system is needed if we are to feed the 800 million people who are hungry today and the additional 2 billion people who will be undernourished by 2050. The Kingdom of Morocco has always invested in agriculture and fertile fertilizers, particularly through South-South cooperation in Africa, which has more than half of the world's uncultivated arable land. Under the royal guidelines set out by His Majesty the King Mohammed VI, food security is a strategic priority for Morocco and is at the heart of its new development model for 2035.

Africa has a young population and a huge continental market of over a billion people. Morocco therefore strongly supports the African free trade area, which has the potential to stimulate the exchange of food products between African countries at lower cost, improve farmers' income and promote agroindustry. In order to build resilience, it is also imperative to invest in sustainable food systems and foster new opportunities in this sector for women farmers and young people. Strengthening the agricultural sector can create jobs and nourish self-sufficiency, including for countries in vulnerable situations.

The protection of civilians is primarily the responsibility of States. Peacekeeping operations, when mandated, play a critical role in this regard by ensuring and strengthening the political process and deploying in areas where civilians are potentially at risk. The humanitarian action to protect civilians must be clearly dissociated from political objectives and protected from instrumentalization by any party to the conflict.

In order to better protect humanitarian personnel and ensure the smooth delivery of humanitarian assistance, mandated missions should deploy adequate protection mechanisms to ensure that civilians are not targeted by any armed groups. All parties, in particular host countries, must respect international humanitarian law, fulfil their obligations to protect civilians and ensure access and delivery of humanitarian aid to intended recipients. Increased coordination between Member States, the United Nations and its agencies and civil society organizations active in the humanitarian field is necessary to avoid any violations of international humanitarian law and ensure safe and secure access to humanitarian assistance for civilians. Humanitarian actors must be able to carry out their noble mandate safely and without political interference.

Furthermore, we consider it to be of paramount importance to encourage a preventive approach to the protection of civilians, which can be developed through capacity-building in the countries concerned, the rule of law, the guarantee of good governance, the entrenchment of a culture of human rights and the establishment of early-warning mechanisms capable of detecting pre-conflict situations and avoiding their transformation into open and deadly confrontations with heavy casualties and damage among civilians. Armed conflicts and economic, political and environmental factors should not be seen as isolated. Rather, they are mutually reinforcing and often cyclical in nature. Over time, they erode people's resilience, which has severe humanitarian consequences.

In conclusion, I would underline that Morocco remains convinced that innovative partnerships in this area will make it possible to deepen and develop promising synergies to ensure the security and dignity of civilians in conflicts.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Lebanon.

Ms. Mrad (Lebanon): Allow me, through you, Mr President, to thank, on behalf of my delegation, the Permanent Mission of Switzerland for organizing today's open debate held in the presence of His Excellency Mr. Alain Berset, President of the Swiss Confederation.

(*spoke in Arabic*)

At a time where crises are more frequent, complex and severe than ever before, and with far-reaching implications, defenceless civilians remain the first

victims, whether these crises stem from human-made conflicts, such as armed conflicts, or natural disasters, where they have no hand in what is happening to them. The theme of today's meeting, thankfully selected by the Swiss presidency of the Security Council for consideration by the Council, revolves principally and exclusively on ensuring the security and dignity of civilians in armed conflicts.

I come from a country whose citizens have known armed conflicts, starting with the civil wars that tore it apart, burdened its economy, displaced its people and claimed the lives of many unarmed people who left behind grieving mothers who wait for the return of their husbands or sons. In time, those mothers have lost hope that they will ever come back alive. I represent a country where unarmed people have paid the price for regional armed conflict — with their lives and their livelihoods.

The images of the soft bodies of children and mothers, unarmed civilians, who turned to the Fijian battalion of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon in the south of our country in 1996 for refuge from Israeli shelling in order to find shelter under international legitimacy, remain clear and vivid in the national memory of Lebanon. These images are a burden on the conscience of the international community, one of whose sites, belonging to the United Nations and sheltering defenceless people, had been exposed to deliberate, intense and systematic Israeli shelling that claimed the lives of women, children and elderly people.

Armed conflicts punish citizens who have nothing to do with these conflicts. They have not participated in nor contributed to the conflicts. They have no say in them. They are just on the receiving end. At times they are used as human shields, in the truest sense of the word as well as metaphorically, between the parties to the conflict. They are used to as a means to punish opponent Governments and regimes just as economic embargoes or unilateral coercive measures are used to suffocate defenceless civilians and ruin their livelihoods.

When we speak about the protection of civilians in armed conflicts, including ensuring their food security, it is incumbent on the international community to exert pressure to open the ports and land and air routes to deliver humanitarian assistance and supplies and food items to all defenceless civilians under siege without

discrimination. Humanitarian assistance to unarmed citizens and the identification of who is in need is not a matter of *à la carte* choosing.

At times of conflict, civilians are at the highest level of vulnerability, in particular in their safety and security, be it food security or otherwise. What if those civilians belong to vulnerable groups that are on the receiving end of what is happening and are in no way part of it? In this regard, it is important to highlight the direct targeting of reporters and correspondents during their coverage of these conflicts. Their only weapon is their pens, helmets and vests. A stark example of this is the killing last year of Palestinian journalist Shireen Abu Akleh.

As we see the arms race heat up and the area of armed conflicts in the world expand, it is time to change approaches and reprioritize. As we are seeking to identify the most effective ways to protect civilians in times such as this, it is incumbent on the international community to put an end to the roots of conflict and the causes of its proliferation. I refer in this regard not just to the arms trade, but also international proxy wars. Instead of interfering in a post facto manner so as to contain the consequences of the crisis and conflict, we might instead address the root causes of conflict and adopt a package of precautionary measures that have at their core the objective of inclusive and sustainable development governing all aspects of life.

In conclusion, as we are preparing for the landmark Sustainable Development summit, we call on the international community, together with all the States Members of the United Nations that are making policy in the decision-making bodies of the Organization, to pay due attention today to the humanitarian development nexus, find sustainable solutions and increase the capability of people to adapt and persevere, and strengthen concepts of security and stability.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Azerbaijan.

Mr. Aliyev (Azerbaijan): At the outset, I would like to thank the Swiss presidency for convening this important meeting.

As the Secretary-General underlines in his report (S/2023/345), the strengthened protection of civilians requires far greater political will and commitment to respecting international humanitarian and human rights law than what has been seen until now. This must clearly be the key objective.

In its almost 30 years of aggression against my country, since the early 1990s, Armenia committed multiple war crimes, resulting in the deaths of tens of thousands of civilians, massive ethnic cleansing, extensive destruction and cultural erasure. The frequency and timing of the attacks, their deliberate targeting of the civilian population and civilian objects, including homes, schools and hospitals, the use of heavy explosive weapons and cluster bombs against densely populated areas and the resulting scale of destruction testify to the clear intent and purpose to terrorize, kill or expel Azerbaijani civilians and prevent the displaced population from returning to their homes.

The scale of the brutalities is also evidenced by almost 4,000 citizens of Azerbaijan going missing in connection with the conflict, including 719 civilians, whose fate Armenia refrains from clarifying. Most of the Azerbaijani captives were subjected to severe torture, including beatings, mutilation, starvation and humiliation. The perpetrators of numerous atrocities committed against the Azerbaijani civilians and other protected persons remain unpunished, in clear disregard of international law. Furthermore, despite the ending of the conflict, Armenia refuses to share accurate and comprehensive information about the hundreds of thousands of landmines it laid on the territory of Azerbaijan that continue to kill and maim civilians.

Essential civilian infrastructure was also targeted. For example, in the fall of 2020, Mingachevir, an Azerbaijani city hosting a key water reservoir and electricity plant, was subjected to repeated missile attacks during the hostilities. Had the missiles succeeded in hitting the facilities, they would have caused devastating floods that would have stretched over 240 kilometres and deprived the population of access to drinking water and electricity.

The aggression also caused long-term and severe damage to the environment of Azerbaijan, with widespread deforestation, land degradation, pillaged and destroyed water infrastructure and polluted water resources. In particular, the neglect and mismanagement of the Sarsang water reservoir, dam and irrigation canal in the formerly occupied territories of Azerbaijan provoked a humanitarian crisis, as 400,000 Azerbaijanis living in the downstream regions were deprived of water both for vital domestic and agricultural purposes, and caused severe environmental impacts such as soil erosion, dehydration and desertification. Those negative impacts remain ongoing to date, along with the continued pollution of transboundary rivers flowing from Armenia into Azerbaijan.

In its resolution of 26 January 2016, the Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe described Armenia's actions as environmental aggression aimed at creating humanitarian and environmental problems for the citizens of Azerbaijan. Earlier this year, Azerbaijan commenced an inter-State arbitration under the Bern Convention on the Conservation of European Wildlife and Natural Habitats to hold Armenia accountable for its extensive destruction of Azerbaijan's environment and biodiversity.

In conclusion, I would like to respond to the statement made earlier by the Deputy Minister for Foreign Affairs of Armenia. The allegations in his statement of the imposition of a so-called blockade of the Lachin-Khankandi road, the disruption of electricity and natural gas by Azerbaijan in its Garabagh economic region and the "genocidal intent" of ethnic cleansing are patently false and provocative. Azerbaijan has never created impediments to the freedom of movement of residents on the roads or their use for the supply of food and medicine or for any other humanitarian purposes, or for access by the International Committee for the Red Cross. This is supported by abundant documented evidence that exposes Armenia's fabrications.

As to the establishment of the border checkpoint, it is an undeniable sovereign right of the Republic of Azerbaijan — the same right as that of any other State — to secure and protect its borders and establish border control. This right is grounded in the foundational principles of territorial sovereignty and integrity and the duty of Azerbaijan to guarantee the security of persons, vehicles and cargo moving along its roads. The Security Council has repeatedly reaffirmed that securing their borders is the sovereign prerogative of States Members of the United Nations. Armenia must understand that misinformation and disinformation are detrimental to the objectives of peace, stability and reconciliation.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Bahrain.

Mr. Alrowaiei (Bahrain) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I should like to extend our congratulations to the President of the Swiss Confederation, Mr. Alain Berset. I thank him for convening today's Security Council meeting. We would also like to thank the Swiss delegation for organizing this very important open debate on the protection of civilians in times of armed conflict, with particular attention on addressing food insecurity and protecting essential services. We also wish to thank

Secretary-General António Guterres and Ms. Spoljaric Egger, President of the International Committee of the Red Cross, for their valuable briefings.

Conflicts remain ongoing all over the world and are the main driver of the rise of acute food insecurity. Conflicts usually result in the destruction or disruption of civilian infrastructure, livelihood-impinging impediments to essential services and displacement. They also obstruct the delivery of humanitarian assistance, result in flare-ups in prices for food, fertilizer and fuel, exacerbate climate change and increase of humanitarian needs, as flagged by the Secretary-General in his most recent annual report on the protection of civilians (S/2023/345).

The Kingdom of Bahrain is aware of the correlation between the environment, natural resources, climate change, human security, food and water. We therefore need a comprehensive, coordinated approach that would address the issue in all of its dimensions — humanitarian and development — and respond to food crises by investing in lasting peace and development. We would like to underscore the importance of ensuring the protection of civilians in armed conflicts by upholding international humanitarian law and international human rights law. Furthermore, we must commit ourselves to implementing resolutions 2417 (2018) and 2573 (2021).

We recently welcomed the extension of the Black Sea Grain Initiative for an additional two months. This agreement is a milestone that will contribute to the promotion and achievement of food security the world over. We would like to extend our appreciation for the efforts of the Republic of Türkiye and the United Nations, which led to this agreement and its extension. We welcome and support all international efforts aimed at resolving the Ukrainian issue peacefully, in accordance with the United Nations Charter and international law.

Moreover, we welcome the signing of the Jeddah declaration between representatives of the Sudanese Armed Forces and Rapid Support Forces from our brotherly republic, the Sudan. The parties have committed themselves to protecting civilians and ensuring their freedom of movement and access to humanitarian and medical assistance, all of which is in keeping with international humanitarian law and international human rights law. We welcome the efforts deployed by the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia and the United States of America aimed at settling the Sudanese crisis through peaceful dialogue.

We remain convinced that the survival and dignity of civilians in times of armed conflict is an issue of paramount importance. We are also mindful of the fact that preventive measures and preparation are vital if we are to protect basic civilian infrastructure and productive capacity, which is necessary for the distribution of food, water, energy, infrastructure and medical assistance. To that end, the Kingdom of Bahrain stresses the need for the international community to focus on the following action points.

First, we must highlight all internationally recognized norms that clearly set out the obligations of parties to a conflict in terms of protecting basic civilian infrastructure, civilian objects and individuals. Secondly, we must support countries affected by conflict to enable them to build resilience in the face of their various challenges, including drafting emergency readiness plans that prioritize the protection of basic civilian infrastructure, civilian objects and persons. Thirdly, we need to promote dialogue between parties to armed conflicts so that they can de-escalate, settle disputes and eventually achieve peaceful outcomes. Fourthly, we need to encourage parties to conflicts to respect international humanitarian law, including the principles of distinction, proportionality and precaution, in order to avoid harming civilians and their livelihoods. Fifthly, we must ensure that humanitarian actors enjoy unhindered, safe and sustainable access so that they may provide necessary assistance and support to affected communities.

In conclusion, we support all initiatives that seek to protect civilians, circumscribe the impact of armed conflicts on human life, and develop preventive measures that can help to uphold the safety, security and dignity of civilians in armed conflict — all with a view to achieving the aspirations of people the world over to peace, stability and growth.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Ethiopia.

Mr. Yoseph (Ethiopia): We thank Switzerland, President of the Security Council, for the month of May, for organizing this open debate. I would also like to thank the Secretary-General, the President of the International Committee of the Red Cross and the other briefers for their remarks this morning. I also recognize the Heads of State and Government who took part in today's important open debate.

Food insecurity and extreme poverty constitute both the cause and consequence of conflicts. Recognizing the exacerbating effects of conflicts on food insecurity, we must redouble our efforts and pursue a peaceful path towards preventing and resolving conflicts. Furthermore, we must address the underlying causes of conflicts, including poverty, lack of resilience and adaptation to the extreme impacts of climate change. It is against this backdrop that I would like to highlight the following three brief points, based mainly on my country's experience.

First, we recognize that conflict is one of the factors contributing to food insecurity. The reason food insecurity continues to be the unfortunate experience of people in conflict situations in Africa and other developing countries relates to the structural vulnerability of these countries' economies. Accelerating economic growth and sustainable development and addressing the challenges in and around the agricultural sector are therefore extremely critical. It is important to support national programmes to improve food production and productivity. This has to be coupled with the critical tasks of ensuring macroeconomic stability and debt relief, restructuring and cancellation and addressing investment bottlenecks — all of which contribute to the efforts aimed at alleviating food insecurity. Such measures ensure resilience when instability and conflicts emerge.

Secondly, timely and adequate provision of humanitarian support to those in need of assistance is extremely important. While States bear the primary responsibility to fulfil the humanitarian needs of their populations, we also see a great need for enhanced international cooperation. For humanitarian assistance to meet its objectives, it is extremely crucial that all humanitarian actors operate in full respect of the principles of humanity, neutrality and independence and comply with the laws and sovereignty of host countries. Humanitarian assistance should never be politicized or used to leverage influence or political gain against States. We also see a practical need to give equal consideration to the lives of all people facing humanitarian disasters and to avoid discriminatory practices in humanitarian cooperation.

Thirdly, acting on climate-change commitments to providing developing countries, especially those in Africa, with the necessary resources to adapt to and mitigate the effects of climate change is crucial. The disastrous effects of climate change on water

resources, vegetation coverage, weather patterns and soil fertility continue to pose an existential challenge to the populations that have contributed the least to global warming. We call on all States to discharge their climate-action obligations and invest in building resilience and adaptation to the effects of climate change.

In conclusion, we believe that those measures will help to address the vulnerabilities that underpin the immediate and causal relationship between conflict and food insecurity. The primacy of the peaceful resolution of conflicts and the innate neutrality of humanitarian operations must also be upheld at all times.

The President (*spoke in French*): The representative of India has asked to make a further statement. I now give him the floor.

Mr. Setia (India): I will be brief, in the interests of time. It is unfortunate that Pakistan has chosen to once again misuse a Security Council meeting to propagate false and malicious propaganda against my country and distract from the theme and focus of today's debate.

The union territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh were, are and always will be an integral and inalienable part of India. No amount of rhetoric and propaganda from any country can negate that fact. Pakistan has no *locus standi* to pronounce on or interfere in matters that are internal to India, including the Indian territories under Pakistan's illegal and forcible occupation. The desire for peace and security and progress on the Indian subcontinent is real. It is also widely shared and can be realized. That will surely happen when cross-border terrorism ceases, when Governments come clean to the international community and to their own people, when minorities are not persecuted and not least when we recognize those realities at meetings such as today's.

Going on its past practice and its compulsive obsession with India, Pakistan may speak again and continue its malicious false propaganda against my country, but I shall refrain from responding to it out of respect for the work we have to do.

The President (*spoke in French*): The representative of Pakistan has asked to make a further statement. I now give her the floor.

Mrs. Ijaz (Pakistan): I am compelled to take the floor to respond to the remarks made by the representative of India against my country.

India continues to perpetuate a factually incorrect position year after year. Jammu and Kashmir is internationally recognized as a disputed territory and not an integral part of India. Repeating a wrongful position does not make it acceptable at any point in any forum. The right of the Kashmiri people to self-determination has been recognized and promised to them by the Security Council through its resolutions. For more than seven decades, through force and fraud, India has prevented the Kashmiris from exercising that right and from holding a United Nations-supervised plebiscite to enable them to determine their own political destiny.

India's talk of terrorism is merely an attempt to camouflage its own State terrorism. India has imprisoned the entire Kashmiri leadership; illegally detained thousands of young Kashmiris, including women and children; summarily executed young boys; violently repressed protests and burned down entire neighbourhoods and villages. Indian-occupied Jammu and Kashmir is the most militarized zone in the world, where close to 900,000 security forces personnel have been deployed by India to curb the legitimate struggle of the Kashmiris. Such measures serve only to strengthen the resolve and resilience of the Kashmiri people to continue their struggle against the illegal Indian occupation and intensify their fight for the right to self-determination. Even in the face of the worst atrocities, as evidenced by the thousands of unknown and unmarked mass graves in illegally Indian-occupied Jammu and Kashmir, the innocent people of Jammu and Kashmir remain firm in their claim to the right to self-determination.

Pakistan will keep exposing Indian brutality and inform the international community of the Kashmiris' plight. We ask the world, including the United Nations, to demand that India end its State terrorism and abide by its obligations under international law, including by implementing the relevant Security Council resolutions.

The meeting rose at 8.15 p.m.